

STEWARDSHIP OF YOUR LIFE: A CHRISTIAN APPROACH TO INTENTIONAL SELF- MANAGEMENT



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Stewardship of Your Life: A Christian Approach to Intentional Self-Management

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Preface

Preface

The Creation of this Open Education Resource (OER)

In 2023, the Illinois State Legislature made available \$3 million in funding dedicated to Open Education Resource creation. This money was disbursed to academic institutions throughout the state via a 2-year competitive grant (2024-2026) that was overseen by the Illinois Secretary of State/Illinois State Library and facilitated by the [Consortium of Academic and Research Libraries in Illinois \(CARLI\)](#). This textbook and ancillary materials were part of Trinity Christian College's grant submission entitled *OER CARES: Cultivating Academic Resources to Equip Students*. From the grant, four separate projects were funded, including this one created for INQ 209: Self-Management.

The grant's primary purpose is to develop Open Educational Resources (OER) throughout the state of Illinois to reduce textbook costs for students and encourage student success. Developed OER course materials will be released under a license that permits their free use, reuse, modification, and sharing with others.

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Contributors to the development of this OER textbook/ancillary material include educators, librarians, and staff from Trinity Christian College.

Illinois Secretary of State/Illinois State Library/CARLI Project Staff

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Purpose

Why did we write this book?

In a world filled with distractions and competing priorities, the quest for personal growth and effective self-management has never been more pressing. As professors, we recognized this need and created a course entitled *Self-Management* for our students. As we walked with our students along their journeys of faith and self-discovery while reflecting on our own journeys, we realized that Biblical principles are foundational for navigating life's challenges.

We understand self-management as self-stewardship. Stewards take care of property that does not belong to them. We are stewards of our lives. Ultimately, our lives belong to God. However, we are tasked with the management and stewardship of our lives. In the parable of the talents in Matthew 25:14-30, a master entrusts different amounts of money to three servants. Two of the servants invest the money wisely while one hides it. The two who invested the money wisely were rewarded while the one who hid his talent had it taken away. This parable leads to the central question of this book:

How do we best use the talents, opportunities, personalities, backgrounds, and experiences that God has given us?

The first answer to that question is, “not alone.” We need the Holy Spirit to do his work in us. We organized this book around the fruit of the Spirit: love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, faithfulness, goodness, gentleness, and self-control (Galatians 5:22-23). We believe that when we allow the Holy Spirit to work in us, we can experience personal fulfillment, a deeper connection with God, and a greater impact on those around us.

Although we have grounded this book in a Biblical foundation of self-management as self-stewardship, we draw from both Christian principles and universally applicable strategies from the fields of psychology, leadership, and education. This book is about taking an inventory of the inner so you can function in the outer. So, whether you are a Christian seeking to align your life more closely with your faith or simply desiring self-management techniques, the tools and insights in these pages will help you explore your thoughts, habits, and motivations. Through this exploration, we aim to provide a framework that integrates faith-based values with actionable steps, enabling you to cultivate a life of purpose, discipline, and grace.

Whether you are seeking to manage your time more effectively, set meaningful goals, become more self-aware, or deepen your relationship with God, we hope this book serves as a valuable resource for you.

~ J. Clevering and R. Vinegar

Introduction

Let's Get Started!

The Goal of *Stewarding Your Life*

Self-management is a critical skill that empowers individuals to lead more focused, intentional, and fulfilling lives. For Christians, this journey is rooted in the belief that we are created in God's image, called to steward our time, talents, and resources in a way that honors Him. However, the principles of self-management—such as setting goals, managing stress, cultivating discipline, and fostering positive habits—are universal. Whether you approach these concepts from a faith-based perspective or a secular viewpoint, the strategies for improving self-control, productivity, and emotional well-being are relevant to all.

Our goal in writing *Stewarding Your Life* is to help you discover your true potential. In this book, we will explore self-management through both Christian principles and practical strategies that can be applied by anyone seeking to grow in their ability to manage life effectively, no matter their background or beliefs. As we delve into these principles, you will find insights and tools necessary for personal transformation that can change how you approach challenges, relationships, and personal growth, helping you live with greater purpose, peace, and intentionality both academically and personally. **We encourage you to make this text your own and find new and creative ways of applying the principles discussed.**

Textbook Overview: Pathways to Growth and Personal Transformation

Stewarding Your Life: A Christian Approach to Intentional Self-Management is organized around four core areas inspired by Clough and Strycharczyk's (2012) framework of **mental toughness**. These areas provide a comprehensive approach to understanding and strengthening self-management:

- **Part I: Confidence - Building a Strong Foundation for Self-Management**
- **Part II: Commitment - Staying Focused and Dedicated**
- **Part III: Challenge - Growing Through Adversity**
- **Part IV: Control - Mastering Personal Responsibility and Flourishing in Life**

Each part of the textbook includes chapters that explore relevant topics and devotional themes tied to these four areas. The goal is to support students not only in gaining knowledge but also in applying it through self-reflection and spiritual growth.

Key features of the textbook include:

- **Self-assessments** in each chapter to help students evaluate their current strengths and areas for development.
- **Guided self-assessment reflection questions** that encourage thoughtful engagement with the content and **self-reflection prompts** to grow deeper personal insight.
- **Devotional themes and reflection prompts** that connect academic and personal practices with biblical principles, grounding self-management in God's love and purpose.

By moving through this structure, students are invited into a transformative journey, one where self-management becomes more than a product or performance, but a faithful stewardship of their lives for God's glory and their own flourishing.

Reference:

Clough, P., & Strycharczyk, D. (2012). *Developing mental toughness: Improving performance, wellbeing and positive behaviour in others*. Kogan Page.

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Confidence - Building a Strong Foundation for Self-Management

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“Confidence is not built overnight; it is the steady result of cultivating self-discipline, embracing challenges, and mastering the art of self-management, one intentional step at a time.” - Dr. Nate Zinsser

Stewarding your life begins with a confident understanding of who you are in Christ. This confidence is not prideful or self-made; it is rooted in the love of God, who created you with purpose and intention. Before you can effectively manage your time, responsibilities, or relationships, you must first embrace the truth that your value comes not from what you do, but from who you are in Him. Therefore, a solid foundation for self-management must begin with love: receiving God’s love, extending it to yourself with grace, and allowing it to shape your inner world. This love transforms your self-perspective, helping you see yourself not through the lens of pressure or performance, but through the eyes of a Creator who delights in you.

As this love takes root, it fosters self-awareness, an honest understanding of your strengths, limitations, desires, and calling. Rather than managing your life from a place of anxiety or striving, you begin to steward it with joy, knowing that you are partnering with God in something meaningful and eternal. True Christian self-management is about cooperation with the One who holds your life in His hands. By cultivating a foundation of love, clarity in self-perspective, and joyful awareness, you prepare your heart and mind to steward your life intentionally.

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1.1: Introduction to Self-Management

Introduction to Self-Management

In a world where distractions abound and pressures mount, the need for effective self-management has never been more pressing. Christian self-management is not merely a collection of time-management techniques but is deeply rooted in biblical principles and a Christ-centered worldview. This approach emphasizes the importance of aligning our daily actions and decisions with our faith, values, and purpose.

This process begins with self-awareness and understanding our strengths, weaknesses, values, and calling. By engaging in self-reflection, we can discern how our unique identities shape our decisions. The teachings of Christ serve as a model for humility, service, and love, guiding us in our journey toward becoming effective stewards of our time and resources.

The demands of life—work obligations, family responsibilities, and social commitments—can easily lead to a sense of being overwhelmed. Many individuals find themselves trapped in a cycle of busyness, often prioritizing tasks over their values. This disconnect can result in stress, anxiety, and a diminished sense of purpose. For Christians, this struggle may also lead to feelings of spiritual inadequacy or disconnection from God. Effective self-management provides a solution, helping individuals reclaim their time and energy and enabling them to serve God and others more fully.

The Integration of Faith and Self-Management

At its core, Christian self-management draws upon the teachings of Scripture. The Bible offers profound insights into the nature of time, stewardship, and personal responsibility. Proverbs 16:3 (NIV) encourages us to “commit to the Lord whatever you do, and he will establish your plans.” This verse illustrates the importance of aligning our personal goals with God’s purposes. Furthermore, Ephesians 5:15-16 (NIV) reminds us to “be very careful, then, how you live—not as unwise but as wise, making the most of every opportunity, because the days are evil.” These passages call Christians to a higher standard of living, one that requires intentionality and mindfulness in how we manage our lives.

Christian self-management goes beyond practical skills; it emphasizes the integration of faith and practice. Throughout this textbook, we will explore various aspects of self-management, including goal setting, prioritization, time management, and personal development. Each chapter will connect these practical tools to Biblical principles, demonstrating how they inform our approach to managing our lives. The scripture reference for each of the eight themes addressed in this textbook can be found in Galatians 5:22-23 (NIV): “But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, forbearance [patience], kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control.”

? Self-Assessment: Cultivating a Positive Attitude for Effective Self-Management 1.1.1

Having a positive attitude is essential to managing your life with clarity, grace, and resilience. While many people assume they are naturally positive, subtle patterns of negative self-talk, doubt, or pessimism can quietly shape how they think, feel, and respond. Positive thinking does not mean ignoring challenges—it means choosing to see possibilities, believe the best, and trust God even in uncertainty. Developing this mindset requires awareness and intentional reflection on how your thoughts and attitudes align with your faith and goals. Use the questions below to examine your inner dialogue and habits with honesty and prayerful openness.

Instructions:

Take a few quiet moments to reflect on each question. Write your thoughts honestly and openly. There are no right or wrong answers, only insights to help you grow. Be kind to yourself as you process and ask God to show you areas where He wants to bring renewal and hope.

1. **How do I usually react to setbacks or challenges?** *Do I try to find the silver lining, or do I tend to dwell on the negative?*
2. **Do I uplift others with my words and actions?** *Would my friends or coworkers describe me as encouraging or supportive?*
3. **How often do I complain or vent about things out of my control?** *Am I aware of how frequently I express dissatisfaction?*
4. **What kind of self-talk do I engage in?** *Is my internal dialogue kind, constructive, or critical?*

5. **When something good happens to others, how do I feel?** *Do I feel genuinely happy for them, or do I experience envy and/or resentment?*
6. **Do I consciously practice gratitude?** *How often do I reflect on what I am thankful for?*
7. **What kind of energy do I bring into the room?** *Do people feel more motivated or relaxed around me?*
8. **How do I handle negativity from others?** *Do I absorb it, deflect it, or try to bring a positive shift?*
9. **Do I believe things will generally work out in the end?** *Am I hopeful about the future?*
10. **Would I want to be around someone who behaves and thinks like me?** *What does that say about my outlook?*

Any thoughts or comments you have about this assessment?

This assessment also available as a PDF download: [1.1.1 - Self-Assessment Cultivating a Positive Attitude for Effective Self-Management](#)

? Self-Assessment Reflection Questions for Cultivating a Positive Attitude 1.1.2

Having a positive attitude is the key to effective self-management. Most people believe they are generally positive but often are not aware of their negative self-talk or behavior. Look back at your self-assessment to answer the following questions:

1. Did any specific instances come to mind as you answered these questions? If so, what are they?
2. If you thought of instances of negative self-talk, negative beliefs, or negative behaviors, in what ways might those negative instances be influencing your faith?
3. Take a few moments to think about your answers overall to all ten of the questions. Based on your overall answers, would you call yourself a positive thinker or a negative thinker? Why?
4. If, overall, you were a positive thinker, what specific steps can you take to continue to be a positive thinker? If, overall, you were a negative thinker, what is one specific step you can take to change your thoughts?

These reflection questions are also available as a PDF download: [1.1.2 - Self-Assessment Reflection Questions for Cultivating a Positive Attitude](#)

? Self-Reflection Prompts: Go Deeper! 1.1.3

As you begin your journey of self-discovery, take time to reflect with honesty, curiosity, and grace. These prompts are meant to help you explore your thoughts, emotions, and experiences in a safe and meaningful way. There is no pressure to have all the answers, just an invitation to notice what you are learning about yourself and where God may be at work in your life. Be open to growth and patience with the process of journaling your reflections. What you discover here can be the beginning of real transformation.

Reflection Prompts:

1. What are you looking forward to the most on this journey and why?
2. What does self-management mean to you?
3. What lies have you believed about yourself that God wants to replace with truth today?
4. When do you feel most confident in your walk with God? What practices help strengthen that?
5. How would your self-management change if you acted from your identity in Christ rather than insecurity or fear?
6. Write a declaration of confidence based on God's truth about you. Read it aloud daily this week.
7. Who or what do you turn to when your confidence is shaken, and how can you turn to God first instead?

These questions are also available as a PDF download: [1.1.3 - Self-Reflection Prompts Go Deeper!](#)

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1.2: Love and Self-Management Devotional

Devotional for Love as the Foundation of Self-Management

Scripture Readings

“But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, forbearance [patience], kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control.” – Galatians 5:22–23 (NIV)

“Dear friends, let us love one another, for love comes from God. Everyone who loves has been born of God and knows God.” – 1 John 4:7 (NIV)

“Love is patient, love is kind. It does not envy, it does not boast, it is not proud...” – 1 Corinthians 13:4 (NIV)

Devotion

At the heart of Christian self-management is love, not as a fleeting feeling, but as a constant, Spirit-led commitment to live intentionally and compassionately. Love, as the first fruit of the Spirit listed in Galatians 5:22–23, is not only the root of all other virtues but also the guiding principle that shapes how we manage our time, emotions, responsibilities, and relationships.

The world often tells us to focus on efficiency, success, or self-fulfillment. Yet Scripture invites us into something deeper: a way of life shaped by God’s love and grounded in grace. As 1 Corinthians 13 reminds us, love is patient and kind. It does not seek its own way but considers others first. This type of love is not passive; it is powerful. It transforms our motives and redirects our priorities.

When love is the foundation of self-management, we move beyond mere productivity. We start making decisions that honor both God and others. We use our energy and resources not only to advance personal goals but also to build up our communities, serve our families, and act with integrity in our daily tasks. Love keeps our self-discipline from becoming self-centered and turns our routines into opportunities for grace.

Ultimately, love-centered self-management aligns us with the heart of God. It cultivates wisdom, fosters meaningful relationships, and allows us to reflect Christ’s character in everything we do. As stewards of God’s grace, our calling is to live intentionally, out of love, through love, and for love.

? Devotional Reflection Prompt: Food for Thought! 1.2.1

Love is an important, foundational pillar for self-management. What kind of love is driving you to work on self-management? Name and explain the love that makes you want to manage your life well.

Think about the many terms that have become part of our vocabulary about love. A couple of popular terms are 'self-love' and 'self-care'. These terms can often sound selfish. However, 1 John 4:19 (NIV) states, “We love because he first loved us.” Building on a foundation of love also means acknowledging that Christ loves us. From a Christian perspective, loving oneself does not have to be selfish. Instead, self-love can be about accepting God’s gracious and abundant love for us.

Do you feel that you can acknowledge that you are valuable, worthwhile, and loved?

Are there ways that loving yourself might help you love others? If so, what are they?

These reflection questions are also available as a PDF download: [1.2.1 - Devotional Reflection Prompts Food for Thought!](#)

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1.3: Self-Perspective - Who are You?

Self-Perspective: Who Are You?

Having the right perspective on yourself is essential to self-management. The first thing to understand about the self is that it is a gift from God. We do not create ourselves. In fact, it was so good that in the beginning, Adam and Eve felt no shame. Then, with the fall into sin, Adam and Eve did feel shame. Ever since, human beings have had a complicated relationship with themselves and with God. Ever since then, human beings have needed a savior. Through God's grace, He has provided us with a savior – Jesus. God's grace is freely given. We do not earn it; we can only accept it. This biblical narrative allows for a unique Christian understanding of the self and self-management. We do not have to earn anything, but we can accept good gifts.

The self is not a project to work on or a task to perfect. It is through grace alone that our selves are saved, not through anything we can accomplish (2 Timothy 1:9; Ephesians 2:8-9). And in fact, God can use even those things we may not like about ourselves – our weaknesses (2 Corinthians 12:9). The self is a gift given by God. By his grace and through his guidance, we can steward our lives. We can act a little more as humankind was intended to act at the beginning of creation – with gratitude for the beautiful gift of ourselves, without shame, and as good stewards.

After understanding yourself as a gracious gift from God, the next step in self-understanding is getting to know that gift. Our selves are made up of personalities, habits, experiences, talents, values, perspectives, and backgrounds. Our selves are made up of triumphs and failures, strengths, and weaknesses. Some would even say our possessions, location, and our unique place in human history are part of what it means to be ourselves. Your friends and family, co-workers, and social standing also affect who you are. To understand yourself better, ask yourself this question:

If I were a character in a book, how would the author introduce me?

God has given us the gift of ourselves, and we are all unique. A clear perspective on all the characteristics that go into making you will help you better understand what it is you need to manage.

Mindfulness and Self-Awareness

One unique thing about each of us is where our minds tend to linger: the past, the present, or the future. One of the founders of the field of mindfulness research, Jon Kabat-Zinn (2003), defined mindfulness as “the awareness that emerges through paying attention on purpose, in the present moment, and nonjudgmentally to the unfolding of experience moment by moment” (p. 145). At the heart of mindfulness is a focus on the present moment and non-judgmental awareness. While thinking about the past can be helpful as we consider how our past decisions and experiences have shaped who we are today, dwelling on the past, judging our past selves, or blaming others in our past can prevent us from moving on toward our future goals. Thinking about future possibilities can be a good motivator to encourage yourself to accomplish your goals; however, only imagining future glory can prevent you from doing what you are called to do in the here and now.

Self-awareness is the foundation that allows us to recognize where our mental focus naturally gravitates (the past, the present, or the future) and how that tendency influences our choices and wellbeing. Becoming aware of these mental patterns is essential for intentional self-management. If we consistently dwell in the past, we may carry guilt, regret, or resentment that weigh us down and distort our present perspective. If we live solely in the future, we risk turning our dreams into distractions, postponing obedience and action for a time that never quite arrives. Self-awareness, then, is not simply about noticing where our thoughts go—it is about choosing, through the Spirit's guidance, to re-center our attention on the now, where faith becomes action and growth begins.

? Self-Assessment: Developing Your Personal Mission Statement 1.3.1

Who are you, and how will it shape your mission?

For this assessment, answer the following questions in as much detail as possible. You will use these answers to write a personal mission statement.

1. As you consider your mindful self-awareness about your tendencies and habits, what nouns or adjectives best describe you? (designer, learner, creative, logical, caring, passionate, etc.)
2. What skills, opportunities, personality traits or talents do you think God especially wants you to use?

3. What gives your life meaning?
4. What are your core values in life?
5. For what do you want to be remembered?

Instructions

Use the answers from the questions above to **write** a personal mission statement. Your mission statement should be about a paragraph in length. Remember, your mission statement can and will change as you grow.

Here is an example of a personal mission statement:

"I want to thrive in a service career that allows me to use my creativity, grow in knowledge from mentors and colleagues, and advance into leadership positions. I value relationships and flexibility. The relationships I value the most are the ones with my family. I want my family to know that they can depend on me. I also want to be flexible so that I can follow God's will for my life, even if that means changes in jobs or location. I want to work closely with patients and make a positive impact on my profession. I want my patients to see God through me. I know working in a career of service can be exhausting, so I want to make sure I have a good balance with personal interests, family, traveling, and participating in my community."

This assessment is also available as a PDF download: [1.3.1 - Self-Assessment Developing Your Personal Mission Statement](#)

? Self-Assessment Reflection Questions for Developing Your Personal Mission Statement 1.3.2

Answer the following questions:

1. Did you find writing your mission statement easy or hard? Why?
2. Are you satisfied with your mission statement, or do you think you need to spend more time understanding yourself or your mission?
3. If you are satisfied with your mission statement, what concrete steps will you take to make sure you are walking in step with your mission?
4. If you are not satisfied with your mission statement, what concrete steps will you take to become satisfied with your mission statement?

These reflection questions are also available as a PDF download: [1.3.2 - Self-Assessment Reflection Questions for Developing Your Personal Mission Statement](#)

? Self-Reflection Prompts: Go Deeper! 1.3.3

Our world tells us to focus on the future.

The Word tells us we are like the lilies of the field, here today and gone tomorrow (Matthew 6:28-29).

Our world tells us that we must do more and be more.

The Word tells us that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us (Romans 5:8).

Our world tells us we must continually work toward self-improvement.

The Word tells us that God saw everything that he had made, and behold, it was very good (Genesis 1:31).

Answer the following questions:

1. What if we saw ourselves, not as projects to work on, but as gifts to steward?
2. Do you tend to see yourself as a project to work on, as a gift to steward, or something else? Give examples of things you do, say, or think, that can illustrate how you see yourself.
3. Mindfulness is about centering the self in the present and being aware of the state of your being in the present. Where do your thoughts tend to go: in the past, the present, or the future? Do you think living there is healthy for you or unhealthy for you? Why or why not?
4. What connections do you see between the concept of self-as-gift, and the concept of mindful self-awareness?

These questions are also available as a PDF download: [1.3.3 - Self-Reflection Prompts Go Deeper!](#)

References:

Kabat-Zinn, J. (2003). Mindfulness-based interventions in context: Past, present, and future. *Clinical Psychology: Science and Practice*, 10(2), 144-156. <https://doi.org/10.1093/clipsy.bpg016>

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1.4: Joy and Its Role in Self-Perspective Devotional

Devotional for Cultivating Joy through Self-Perspective and Self-Awareness

Scripture Readings

"I have told you this so that my joy may be in you and that your joy may be complete." – **John 15:11 (NIV)**

"May the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace as you trust in him, so that you may overflow with hope by the power of the Holy Spirit." – **Romans 15:13 (NIV)**

Devotion

Joy, as a fruit of the Spirit, is more than an emotion; it is a spiritual posture, a settled confidence in God's presence, goodness, and promises. According to Jesus in John 15:11, joy is something He desires to place within us, a complete joy that reflects His own. Paul echoes this in Romans 15:13, connecting joy with trust, peace, hope, and the power of the Holy Spirit.

But what often gets in the way of joy?

This is where **self-awareness** becomes essential. By paying attention to our internal dialogue, emotional patterns, and thought habits, we can begin to recognize the things—both subtle and obvious—that block our experience of joy: comparison, fear, resentment, shame, or distraction. Self-awareness allows us to name these barriers, confront them with grace, and realign our perspective with God's truth.

When we begin to view joy not just as a momentary feeling, but as a lens through which we interpret life, it becomes transformative. Joy is not about ignoring pain or pretending everything is fine. It is about being anchored in something deeper, God's unchanging love and the hope we have in Christ. Joy becomes our strength not because life is always easy, but because God is always present.

So today, consider what it looks like to **cultivate joy** as a spiritual practice—rooted in awareness, perspective, and the faithful presence of God.

? Devotional Reflection Prompts: Food for thought! 1.4.1

1. Where do your mind and heart tend to dwell most—on past regrets, present struggles, or future worries? How might this be affecting your ability to experience joy?
2. What barriers or internal beliefs do you recognize that might be hindering the growth of joy in your life?
3. How do you define joy today? Is it dependent on your circumstances, or grounded in something deeper?
4. Spend a few minutes in quiet prayer, asking God to reveal the areas of your heart where He wants to plant deeper joy. What comes to mind?
5. What is one daily practice you can adopt to become more aware of God's presence and choose joy intentionally, even in small ways?

These questions are also available as a PDF download: [1.4.1 - Devotional Reflection Prompts Food for thought!](#)

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: Commitment - Staying Focused and Dedicated

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*"Success is the sum of small efforts, repeated day in and day out.
Stay committed, keep your eyes on the prize, and trust the process." - Robert Collier*

Once a strong foundation of love, self-awareness, and joy is in place, the next step in stewarding your life is cultivating commitment, a steady dedication to stay focused on what God has called you to do. In a world of distractions and constant change, commitment anchors your heart and actions in God's direction, not just your desires. Christian self-management calls for more than good intentions; it requires thoughtful goal setting that aligns with your values and God's purposes. When your goals are birthed from prayerful discernment, they carry a deep sense of peace, even when they challenge you because they are not rooted in pressure but in trust.

Staying committed also means managing your time wisely, understanding that time is a gift and a resource to be used with care and intention. It involves creating rhythms that support your priorities, rather than chasing after busyness or overcommitting out of fear of missing out. Patience plays a key role here, trusting God's timing, pacing yourself, and resisting the urge to measure progress by worldly standards. Through commitment, peace, and patience, you learn to steward your energy and attention in a way that is sustainable and intentional. This part of the journey is about not only starting well but continuing to grow strong, trusting that God is shaping you through every step.

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2.1: S.M.A.R.T. Goal Setting

The Importance of Goal Setting

Incorporating both short-term and long-term goals into our lives is essential for effective self-management. Short-term goals serve as steppingstones that lead us toward our long-term aspirations. They help us maintain focus and provide opportunities for regular reflection and adjustment.

Long-Term Goals

Long-term goals are those we aim to achieve over an extended period, often spanning several months or years. These goals reflect our broader life vision and aspirations, such as advancing in our careers, completing a degree, or deepening our spiritual journey. Long-term goals provide a sense of purpose and direction, guiding our decisions and actions.

When setting long-term goals, it is crucial to break them down into manageable short-term goals. For instance, if your long-term goal is to obtain a degree, your short-term goals may include enrolling in a specific course, dedicating a set number of hours each week to studying, and completing assignments on time. This breakdown not only makes the long-term goal feel more attainable but also keeps us motivated through tangible progress.

Short-Term Goals

Short-term goals are typically set for a time limit of days, weeks, or months. For example, a short-term goal might include completing a specific project at work, establishing a daily prayer routine, or committing to exercise three times a week. Short-term goals are baby steps that we take on the way to long-term goals. By clearly articulating each short-term goal on your way to your long-term goal, you can see the progress you are making. Accomplishing these goals allows for quick wins that can boost motivation and confidence.

By achieving short-term goals, we build momentum and create a positive feedback loop that encourages us to tackle larger challenges. These goals can also help us assess our progress and make necessary adjustments to our strategies, so we can achieve our long-term goals.

Tool for Goal Setting

Setting clear goals is important for growth and development. Once you understand your mission, you can set goals to achieve that mission. A helpful tool for developing your goals is the S.M.A.R.T. framework developed by George T. Doran in 1981. Having a S.M.A.R.T. goal allows you to look back at your work toward your goal and assess your progress. S.M.A.R.T. goal setting can be incorporated into any domain of life: spiritual, relational, vocational, physical, financial, or educational.

Understanding the S.M.A.R.T. Framework

The S.M.A.R.T. framework is an acronym that stands for:

Specific
Measurable
Achievable
Relevant
Time-bound

We will take a look at each of these letters individually to see how they can be applied to goal setting.

- **Specific:** A specific goal eliminates ambiguity and provides a clear focus. Goals should be clear, usually answering one of the five "W" questions:
 - Who? Identify the people involved.
 - What? Identify the task to be completed.
 - Where? Identify the location.
 - Why? Identify the specific reasons, purpose, or benefits of accomplishing the goal.
 - Which? Identify requirements and constraints.
 - Examples:

- *Unspecific goal:* I will get healthy.
- *Specific goal:* I will get my LDL cholesterol levels down to 130 mg/dL.
- **Measurable:** A goal must have criteria for measuring progress. This allows for tracking accomplishments and motivates as milestones are reached. A measurable goal should be quantifiable and will usually answer questions such as:
 - How many?
 - How will I know when it is accomplished?
 - Examples:
 - *Unmeasurable goal:* I will get closer to God.
 - *Measurable goal:* I will do devotions at least five days a week.
- **Achievable:** Goals should be realistic and attainable. Setting overly ambitious goals can lead to frustration and burnout, while achievable goals encourage persistence. An achievable goal will usually answer the question:
 - How can the goal be accomplished?
 - Examples:
 - *Probably unachievable goal:* I will get a job with a \$100,000 salary upon graduation.
 - *Probably achievable goal:* I will get a job that pays enough that I can move out of my parent's house within a year after graduation.
- **Relevant:** A goal must align with broader life objectives and values. Relevant goals ensure that we are investing our time and energy into what truly matters. A relevant goal can answer yes to these questions:
 - Does this seem worthwhile?
 - Is this the right time?
 - Does this match my other efforts/needs?
 - Are you the right person?
 - Is it applicable in my current socio- economic- technical environment?
 - Examples:
 - *Irrelevant goal* (if your mission does not involve a collector's hobby): I will frame my entire childhood collection of Pokémon cards.
 - *Relevant goal* (if your mission statement includes family relationships): I will call my parents at least once a week.
- **Time-bound:** Goals should have a clear deadline or time limit. This creates a sense of urgency and helps prioritize tasks effectively. A time-bound goal will usually answer the question:
 - When?
 - What can I do today?
 - What can I do six weeks from now?
 - What can I do six months from now?
 - Examples:
 - *Goal without a time limit:* I will get an internship.
 - *Goal with a time limit:* I will get an internship agreement signed by the end of my junior year.

Applying the S.M.A.R.T. Framework to Goal Setting

To illustrate the S.M.A.R.T. approach, let us consider an example of setting a goal related to personal development. Suppose your long-term goal is to improve your spiritual life. Here is how you can apply the S.M.A.R.T. criteria:

- **Specific:** Instead of saying, "I want to be more spiritual," specify, "I will read the Bible for 20 minutes each day."
- **Measurable:** You can measure this by tracking the number of days you read each week. For example, aim to read every day and keep a journal of your reflections.
- **Achievable:** Assess your current schedule to ensure that 20 minutes a day is realistic. Adjust as needed; if 20 minutes feels overwhelming, start at 10.
- **Relevant:** Ensure that this goal aligns with your broader aspirations, such as deepening your relationship with God and understanding Scripture more fully.
- **Time-bound:** Set a deadline for this goal, such as "I will commit to this daily practice for the next three months."

The Benefits of S.M.A.R.T. Goal Setting

Utilizing the S.M.A.R.T. framework offers several benefits:

- *Clarity and Focus*: Clearly defined goals help us concentrate our efforts on what truly matters, reducing distractions.
- *Motivation*: Achieving short-term goals fosters a sense of accomplishment and encourages further progress, fueling our intrinsic motivation.
- *Accountability*: Measurable goals allow for self-assessment and accountability. Regularly reviewing progress helps identify areas for improvement.
- *Adaptability*: By setting time-bound goals, we can regularly assess our strategies and adjust as necessary, ensuring alignment with our evolving priorities and circumstances.
- *Alignment with Faith*: Setting goals within the S.M.A.R.T. framework encourages us to reflect on our values and aspirations, ensuring our pursuits honor God and reflect our faith.

Let's Recap

S.M.A.R.T. goal setting is a powerful tool for effective self-management, enabling us to define our aspirations and track our progress with clarity and purpose. By integrating both short-term and long-term goals into our lives, we can navigate our journeys with confidence, resilience, and a sense of direction.

As we strive to manage our lives effectively, let us approach our goals with intention and faith, aligning our desires with God's will. In doing so, we can cultivate a life of purpose, fulfillment, and service to others, reflecting the light of Christ in all that we do.

? S.M.A.R.T Goals Worksheet 2.1.1

Brainstorming is a helpful way to begin to define your goals. When writing your aspirations, such as career, health, relationships, and personal growth, be specific! Describe your goals in detail, visualizing the outcome you want to achieve.

Use this S.M.A.R.T. Goals Worksheet to assist you in creating your goals for each of the six different areas of your life:

- **Spiritual** (religious)
- **Educational** (degree, graduate school, etc.)
- **Vocational** (career/professional)
- **Financial**
- **Physical** (health/fitness)
- **Personal** (family/relationships)

Remember - S.M.A.R.T. is an acronym.

- Specific
- Measurable
- Attainable
- Relevant
- Time-related

Instructions

This exercise will help you brainstorm, determine your aspirations, and describe your goals in detail. Each area (Spiritual, Educational, Vocational, etc.) is listed on a separate sheet. You will answer the same seven questions for each of the six different areas.

For each area, begin by writing your goal as clearly and concisely as possible (Question 1). Then answer the related questions (Questions 2-6). Conclude by revising your goal (Question 7).

Spiritual Goal

1. What is my **Spiritual Goal**?
2. **Specific**: What will the goal accomplish?
3. **Measurable**: How will you know when you have reached this goal (list at least two indicators)?

4. **Achievable:** Is achieving this goal realistic with effort and commitment? Do you have the necessary knowledge, skills, abilities, and resources to accomplish the goal? Will meeting the goal challenge you without defeating you?
5. **Relevant:** Why is this goal significant to your life?
6. **Time-bound:** What is the established completion date, and does that completion date create a practical sense of urgency?
7. After answering the above questions, create a **Revised Spiritual Goal**.

Educational Goal

1. What is my **Educational Goal**?
2. **Specific:** What will the goal accomplish?
3. **Measurable:** How will you know when you have reached this goal (list at least two indicators)?
4. **Achievable:** Is achieving this goal realistic with effort and commitment? Do you have the necessary knowledge, skills, abilities, and resources to accomplish the goal? Will meeting the goal challenge you without defeating you?
5. **Relevant:** Why is this goal significant to your life?
6. **Time-bound:** What is the established completion date, and does that completion date create a practical sense of urgency?
7. After answering the above questions, create a **Revised Educational Goal**.

Vocational/Career Goal

1. What is my **Vocational/Career Goal**?
2. **Specific:** What will the goal accomplish?
3. **Measurable:** How will you know when you have reached this goal (list at least two indicators)?
4. **Achievable:** Is achieving this goal realistic with effort and commitment? Do you have the necessary knowledge, skills, abilities, and resources to accomplish the goal? Will meeting the goal challenge you without defeating you?
5. **Relevant:** Why is this goal significant to your life?
6. **Time-bound:** What is the established completion date, and does that completion date create a practical sense of urgency?
7. After answering the above questions, create a **Revised Vocational/Career Goal**.

Financial Goal

1. What is my **Financial Goal**?
2. **Specific:** What will the goal accomplish?
3. **Measurable:** How will you know when you have reached this goal (list at least two indicators)?
4. **Achievable:** Is achieving this goal realistic with effort and commitment? Do you have the necessary knowledge, skills, abilities, and resources to accomplish the goal? Will meeting the goal challenge you without defeating you?
5. **Relevant:** Why is this goal significant to your life?
6. **Time-bound:** What is the established completion date, and does that completion date create a practical sense of urgency?
7. After answering the above questions, create a **Revised Financial Goal**.

Physical/Health/Wellness/Fitness Goal

1. What is my **Physical/Health/Wellness/Fitness Goal**?
2. **Specific:** What will the goal accomplish?
3. **Measurable:** How will you know when you have reached this goal (list at least two indicators)?
4. **Achievable:** Is achieving this goal realistic with effort and commitment? Do you have the necessary knowledge, skills, abilities, and resources to accomplish the goal? Will meeting the goal challenge you without defeating you?
5. **Relevant:** Why is this goal significant to your life?
6. **Time-bound:** What is the established completion date, and does that completion date create a practical sense of urgency?
7. After answering the above questions, create a **Revised Physical/Health/Wellness/Fitness Goal**.

Personal/Relational Goal

1. What is my **Personal/Relational Goal**?
2. **Specific:** What will the goal accomplish?
3. **Measurable:** How will you know when you have reached this goal (list at least two indicators)?

4. **Achievable:** Is achieving this goal realistic with effort and commitment? Do you have the necessary knowledge, skills, abilities, and resources to accomplish the goal? Will meeting the goal challenge you without defeating you?
5. **Relevant:** Why is this goal significant to your life?
6. **Time-bound:** What is the established completion date, and does that completion date create a practical sense of urgency?
7. After answering the above questions, create a **Revised Personal/Relational Goal**.

The S.M.A.R.T. Goals Worksheet is also available as a PDF download: [2.1.1 - S.M.A.R.T. Goals Worksheet](#)

? Self-Assessment: Vision Casting - Using Images to Enhance Your Goals 2.1.2

Creative Project Instructions: Vision Casting your SMART Goals

Create a Vision Board for your S.M.A.R.T. Goals: You will create a vision board using the six S.M.A.R.T. goals you developed in your write-up. You may draw your images, use digital images, or whatever image format you desire if it explains your six S.M.A.R.T. goals.

A **vision board** is a visual representation of your goals and aspirations, using images, words, and symbols to inspire and guide you toward achieving them. It can be a powerful tool for goal setting.

A vision board is a visual representation of your goals and aspirations, using images, words, and symbols to inspire and guide you toward achieving them. It can be a powerful tool for goal setting.

1. Gather Visual Elements:

1. **Images:** Collect pictures that represent your goals, dreams, and aspirations.
 - **Use online resources:** Pinterest, Instagram, Google Images.
 - **Cut out images from magazines or print them.**
2. **Quotes:** Include inspirational quotes or bible verses that resonate with your vision.
3. **Words:** Use affirmations, mantras, or keywords that align with your goals.
4. **Symbols:** Incorporate symbols that have meaning for you.

2. Arrange Your Vision Board:

1. **Choose a layout:** You can arrange your elements in a grid, a collage, or a more abstract design.
2. **Use a physical board or a digital tool:** You can use a corkboard, poster board, or online apps like Canva
3. **Consider your personal preferences:** Make it visually appealing and inspiring to you.

3. Examples of Vision Board Elements:

1. **Self-Image:** Include a picture of yourself embodying your vision, or images of people you admire.
2. **Emotions:** Write down the emotions you want to feel when you achieve your goals.
3. **Environment:** Include images of your dream home, travel destinations, or places that inspire you.
4. **Community:** Represent your desired social connections and the people you want to be surrounded by.
5. **Mindset:** Use quotes or words that reflect your desired mindset and values.
6. **Mantras:** Write down affirmations that will help you stay motivated and focused.
7. **Interests:** Include images or words that represent your hobbies and passions.
8. **Art:** Incorporate artwork that inspires you and fuels your creativity.

4. Display and Maintain Your Vision Board:

1. **Put it in a prominent location:** Make it visible so you can see it regularly and stay motivated.
2. **Review and update periodically:** As your goals evolve, update your vision board to reflect your new aspirations.
3. **Regularly reflect on your progress:** Journal about your achievements and celebrate your milestones.

This worksheet is also available as a PDF download: [2.1.2 Self-Assessment Vision-Casting - Using images to enhance your goals](#)

✓ Self-Reflection Prompts: Go Deeper! 2.1.3

Answer the following questions:

1. Which areas have you focused on when setting goals in the past? Did you reach those goals? What were some of the challenges you had with reaching those goals?
2. In the context of setting SMART goals, what are three key areas that you would like to focus on in the next 3 months?

These questions are also available as a PDF download: [2.1.3 - Self-Reflection Prompts Go Deeper!](#)

References:

Doran, G. T. (1981). There's a S.M.A.R.T. way to write management's goals and objectives. *Management Review*, 70(11), 35-36.

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2.2: Peace and Goal Setting Devotional

Devotional for Peace and Goal Setting

Scripture Readings

*“You will keep in perfect peace those whose minds are steadfast, because they trust in you.” – **Isaiah 26:3 (NIV)***

*“Peace I leave with you; my peace I give you. I do not give to you as the world gives. Do not let your hearts be troubled and do not be afraid.” – **John 14:27 (NIV)***

*“In peace I will lie down and sleep, for you alone, Lord, make me dwell in safety.” – **Psalms 4:8 (NIV)***

*“Do not be anxious about anything, but in every situation, by prayer and petition, with thanksgiving, present your requests to God. And the peace of God, which transcends all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.” – **Philippians 4:6-7 (NIV)***

Devotion

Goal setting can be a powerful tool for growth, but it often brings with it stress, uncertainty, and the pressure of future outcomes. From a Christian perspective, however, the pursuit of goals is not meant to rob us of peace. In fact, peace is essential if we hope to set and achieve goals in a way that reflects God's heart.

God's peace is not a surface-level calm that disappears when life gets hard. It is a deep, sustaining presence that steadies our minds and hearts, especially when things do not go according to plan. Whether you are launching something new or recalibrating after a setback, peace helps you stay grounded, not in your own control, but in God's sovereignty.

When integrated with the S.M.A.R.T. goal-setting framework (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound), peace becomes the atmosphere in which our goals can thrive. Rather than setting goals from a place of anxiety or pressure, we can set them prayerfully, reflectively, and purposefully anchored in trust.

When setbacks come (and they will), peace reminds us that God is still at work. When fear of failure creeps in, peace reminds us that God is faithful. When uncertainty clouds our vision, peace provides clarity, not from knowing all the answers, but from knowing the One who leads us step by step.

? Devotional Reflection Prompt: Food for Thought! 2.2.1

1. Do you have a sense of peace about your goals? Why or why not?
2. What advice would you give someone about how to find peace while working toward their goals?
3. What do you find yourself saying to God when you do not achieve your goals?

These questions are also available as a PDF download: [2.2.1 - Devotional Reflection Prompt Food for Thought!](#)

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2.3: Time Management with a Purpose

Time Management with a Mission

In today's fast-paced world, effective time management is crucial for achieving our goals. The ability to prioritize tasks, stay organized, and overcome procrastination is essential not just for productivity but for living a life aligned with our values and mission. As Christians, we are called to steward our time wisely, recognizing that each moment is an opportunity to serve God and fulfill our purpose. This section explores practical techniques for enhancing organizational skills, overcoming procrastination, and managing time effectively while remaining focused on our God-given aspirations.

Understanding the Importance of Time Management

Time is a precious gift from God. Ephesians 5:15-16 (ESV) encourages us to "look carefully...how you walk, not as unwise but as wise, making the best use of the time, because the days are evil." This Scripture highlights the importance of being intentional with our time, ensuring that we use it to reflect our values and fulfill our mission.

Effective time management allows us to achieve more with less stress. By managing our time well, we can create space for our spiritual practices, relationships, and personal growth, thereby enhancing our overall wellbeing. Additionally, good time management cultivates a sense of purpose and accomplishment, aligning our daily actions with our long-term goals.

Techniques for Organizational Skills

Organizational skills are foundational to effective time management. They help us structure our time and resources efficiently, allowing us to focus on what truly matters. Here are several techniques to enhance your organizational skills:

Prioritize Your Tasks

Start by identifying your most important tasks (MITs) each day. Use the Eisenhower Matrix (Allen, 2001), which categorizes tasks based on urgency and importance. This method divides tasks into four quadrants:

	Urgent	Not urgent
Important	Quadrant I Emergencies  DO	Quadrant II Planning  SCHEDULE
Not important	Quadrant III Interruptions  DELEGATE	Quadrant IV Time-wasters  ELIMINATE

Figure 2.3.1: Eisenhower Matrix. (Cmglee, CC BY-SA 4.0, via [Wikimedia Commons](#).)

- *Urgent and Important*: Do these tasks immediately.
- *Important but Not Urgent*: Schedule these tasks for later.
- *Urgent but Not Important*: Delegate or minimize these tasks.
- *Not Urgent and Not Important*: Eliminate or limit these tasks.

By prioritizing your tasks, you can focus on activities that align with your goals, ensuring that you invest your time wisely.

Create a Daily and Weekly Plan

Establishing a daily and weekly planning routine helps structure your time effectively. Each week, set aside time to review your goals and outline your tasks. Create a to-do list for each day that includes both short-term tasks and long-term objectives. This

process provides clarity and helps you stay on track.

Use Tools and Resources

Leverage technology and tools to enhance your organization. Calendar apps, task management software, and digital note-taking applications can streamline your planning process. Consider using a physical planner if you prefer a tangible approach. Whatever method you choose, ensure that it works for you and helps you visualize your schedule and tasks.

Set Boundaries and Limit Distractions

Establishing boundaries is crucial for maintaining focus and productivity. Designate specific times for work, study, and spiritual practices. Communicate these boundaries to others to minimize interruptions. Additionally, limit distractions by creating a dedicated workspace and using tools that help block distracting websites or notifications during work hours.

Overcoming Procrastination

Procrastination can hinder our ability to manage time effectively and achieve our goals. It often stems from fear, overwhelm, or lack of motivation. Here are several strategies to help overcome procrastination:

- *Identify the Root Causes:* Reflect on why you may be procrastinating. Are you feeling overwhelmed by the task? Are you afraid of failure? Identifying the root causes can help you address them more effectively. Consider journaling your thoughts to gain clarity and insight.
- *Break Tasks into Smaller Steps:* Large tasks can feel daunting and lead to procrastination. Break them down into smaller, manageable steps. For example, if your goal is to write a report, you could outline the sections, set deadlines for each part, and focus on completing one section at a time. This approach makes tasks feel less overwhelming and provides a sense of accomplishment as you complete each step.
- *Use the Pomodoro Technique:* The Pomodoro Technique is a time management method that promotes focused work sessions followed by short breaks. Set a timer for 25 minutes and work on a specific task without distractions. After the timer goes off, take a 5-minute break. Repeat this cycle, and after completing four sessions, take a longer break of 15-30 minutes. This technique can enhance focus and productivity while reducing the tendency to procrastinate.
- *Cultivate Accountability:* Share your goals and deadlines with a friend, mentor, or accountability partner. Regular check-ins can motivate you to stay on track and reduce the temptation to procrastinate. Knowing that someone else is aware of your goals can provide the encouragement needed to follow through.

Managing Time Effectively While Staying Focused on God-Given Goals

Integrating spiritual practices into your time management strategy is essential for maintaining balance and purpose. Here are techniques to help you stay focused on your spiritual and personal goals:

- *Incorporate Spiritual Practices into Your Routine:* Make time for prayer, meditation, or Bible study a non-negotiable part of your daily routine. These spiritual practices help ground you and provide clarity, enabling you to approach your tasks with a focused mindset. For example, you might begin each day with a brief devotional and prayer, asking for guidance in your tasks and decisions.
- *Align Your Goals with Your Values:* Ensure that your goals align with your values. Reflect on your mission statement: what matters most to your relationships, service, and personal growth, and set goals that reflect these priorities. This alignment will make it easier to stay committed to your goals, even when distractions arise.
- *Schedule Time for Reflection:* Regularly set aside time to reflect on your progress and the alignment of your actions with your spiritual mission. This could involve journaling, meditating, or discussing your journey with a mentor. Reflection allows you to evaluate your effectiveness in managing time and to recalibrate your goals, as necessary.
- *Embrace Flexibility:* While structure is important, flexibility is equally vital. Life is unpredictable, and sometimes our plans may need adjustment. Approach your schedule with an open heart, allowing room for the unexpected. Trust that God is guiding your path and be willing to adapt your plans, as necessary.

Effective time management is essential for fulfilling our goals. By enhancing our organizational skills, overcoming procrastination, and focusing on our mission, we can create a balanced life that honors God and reflects our values.

As we implement these techniques, let us remember that time management is not merely about productivity; it is about living purposefully. Each moment presents an opportunity to commit to serve, grow, and deepen our relationship with God. By managing our time wisely, we position ourselves to live out our calling, impacting the world around us in meaningful ways.

? Self-Assessment: Effective Time Usage 2.3.1

Answer the questions below by answering either **“true of me”** or **“not true of me”**

1. When faced with a task, I get overwhelmed easily.
2. When faced with a task, I feel like I will not be able to get it right.
3. I do not see the value in most of the tasks I need to accomplish.
4. I want to make sure that all my tasks are accomplished perfectly.
5. I believe I work better under pressure.
6. I honestly forget about a lot of the tasks I must do.
7. When I procrastinate and fail, then I have an excuse for my failure.
8. I value spontaneity.
9. A lot of other people put demands on my time.
10. I check my calendar and to-do lists constantly.

This assessment is also available as a PDF download: [2.3.1 - Self-Assessment Effective Time Usage](#)

? Self-Assessment Reflection Questions for Effective Time Usage 2.3.2

1. Look back at your response to the self-assessment for time management. Do you need to make any changes in terms of time management? If so, what changes do you need to make?
2. Overall, do you think God is calling you to be less rigid about your time management, more structured with your time management, or are you right where He needs you to be? Explain.
3. Look at the prompts for which you circled “true of me.” Do you notice any patterns? Do any of the statements stand out to you particularly? If so, what statements or patterns stood out to you?
4. Looking at your response to the question above, how would you describe your relationship to time management?
5. Are you an over-scheduler? Are you a procrastinator? Do you lack self-discipline? Do you lack boundaries? Are you afraid of failure? Are you afraid of the responsibility that may come with success? Are you over-committed? Explain.

These reflection questions are also available as a PDF download: [2.3.2 - Self-Assessment Reflection Questions for Effective Time Usage](#)

? Self-Reflection Prompts: Go Deeper! 2.3.3

In the previous section, we discussed goal setting, and we worked on developing S.M.A.R.T. goals. In this section, we are learning about time management. We are looking at how we can develop our organizational skills to create margin and balance in our lives. What you give energy to impacts everything!

1. How do you demonstrate suitable time management and energy management?
2. If you could only achieve one thing today, what would it be? Have you achieved it?
3. What is your energy level on a scale of 1 -10 right now? Is this energy level appropriate to get what you want to achieve today completed?
4. What changes need to be made to your weekly schedule?
5. What are persistent time wasters for you?
6. Is procrastination an issue for you?

These reflection questions are also available as a PDF download: [2.3.3 - Self-Reflection Prompts Go Deeper!](#)

Reference:
Allen (2001).

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2.4: Patience and Time Management Devotional

Devotional for Patience in Time Management

Scripture Readings

*“Be very careful, then, how you live—not as unwise but as wise, making the most of every opportunity, because the days are evil. Therefore, do not be foolish, but understand what the Lord’s will is.” – **Ephesians 5:15-17 (NIV)***

*“The plans of the diligent lead to profit as surely as haste leads to poverty.” – **Proverbs 21:5 (NIV)***

*“In their hearts humans plan their course, but the Lord establishes their steps.” – **Proverbs 16:9 (NIV)***

Devotion

In a world that rewards speed, multitasking, and constant productivity, **patience** is often undervalued. Yet, Scripture teaches us that patience is a fruit of the Spirit, essential not only for our relationships but also for how we manage our time and structure our lives.

Starting a major task or pursuing a long-term goal can feel overwhelming. We may begin with excitement, but as the process stretches on, frustration, discouragement, or even burnout can creep in. That is where patience becomes our spiritual advantage. It helps us manage delays, stay organized, and persevere through the slow and steady work of meaningful progress.

When we experience interruptions or face unexpected changes in our plans, patience invites us to see these moments not as detours but as divine opportunities. God may be teaching us something valuable about ourselves, our goals, or His timing. This mindset shift is crucial for maintaining peace and focus when things do not go according to schedule.

Patience also allows us to invest in long-term growth. Rather than rushing toward results, we can prioritize diligently, celebrate small wins, and adjust our systems as needed. Whether you are setting up a new calendar, learning to balance school and work, or creating space for rest, patience gives you the grace to keep going, even when it takes more time and effort than expected.

Ultimately, **time management is not just about efficiency; it is about patience and faithfulness**. God calls us to steward our time wisely, trusting Him to establish our steps, even when the path is slower than we had hoped.

? Devotional Reflection Prompt: Food for Thought! 2.4.1

As we work on self-management, let us remember that patience is not simply about waiting; it is about trusting in God’s perfect timing and actively engaging in the journey. By cultivating patience in our lives, we reflect God’s character and grace and fulfill our calling to live out our mission with intention.

1. Do you find yourself able to trust God’s perfect timing? What areas of your life are you able to trust God with patience, and what areas of your life do you become impatient with God?
2. What is your biggest challenge: being patient with yourself, being patient with others, or being patient with God? Why do you think that is your biggest challenge?
3. What do you need to pray about in terms of patience and time management this week?

These questions are also available as a PDF download: [2.4.1 - Devotional Reflection Prompt Food for Thought!](#)

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Challenge - Growing Through Adversity

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"Strength grows in the moments when you think you can't go on, but you keep going anyway.

Every challenge is an opportunity to rise stronger and wiser." - William H. Johnsen

The path of self-management will inevitably lead through seasons of challenges. Obstacles, disappointments, and internal struggles are not signs of failure; they are opportunities for growth and deeper dependence on God. In this part of the journey, self-motivation becomes essential, not as a form of self-reliance, but as a response to God's grace and calling. The ability to keep going when things are difficult flows from a heart anchored in faithfulness: choosing to trust God's presence and promises even when the way forward is not clear.

As you navigate challenges, managing your emotions with honesty and maturity allows you to respond rather than react. Kindness toward yourself and others becomes a powerful tool for resilience, reminding you that progress does not require perfection. Every difficulty is a chance to lean into the character of Christ, who endured hardship with love and unwavering focus. Through faithfulness, emotional wisdom, and compassion, you not only overcome adversity but are transformed by it. In God's hands, every challenge becomes part of the refining process that shapes you into a more faithful steward of the life He has entrusted to you.

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3.1: Self-Motivation

Self-Motivation – Staying Motivated when the Going Gets Tough

Self-motivation is a crucial element of effective self-management. Understanding the motivation for our goals and commitments can help us reassess those goals and commitments. Sometimes we start a commitment thinking that it is aligned with our mission, only to realize the requirements of the commitment have changed. Sometimes we pursue goals that other people have set for us and are not really in line with our mission or values. Other times, our vision of self-stewardship changes and our goals need to change too. Being able to label the type of motivation that we have for our various activities can help us prioritize and adjust. Colossians 3:23-24 (NIV) instructs us, “Whatever you do, work at it with all your heart, as working for the Lord, not for human masters, since you know that you will receive an inheritance from the Lord as a reward.” This passage highlights the importance of aligning our motivations with God’s purposes, encouraging us to pursue endeavors that glorify Him.

This chapter will highlight two useful concepts from psychology: the distinction between intrinsic and extrinsic motivation and the distinction between mastery and performance goals.

Intrinsic Motivation

Intrinsic motivation has been defined by Ryan and Deci (2000) as “the doing of an activity for its inherent satisfaction rather than for some separable consequence” (p. 56). In other words, motivation to move comes as a free choice instead of pressures or rewards that come outside of the activity. Humans do intrinsically-motivated activities because they are rewarding in and of themselves and we find them interesting and enjoyable. Examples might include:

- Ironing clothes because you enjoy the smell of the steam, the satisfaction of seeing wrinkles become flat and smooth, and the soothing experience of repetitive action.
- Going to church and experiencing the joy of worship and communal singing.
- Going to the gym to feel the stiffness in your muscles loosen, the experience of your body extending itself, and the grounding of your physical self.

Extrinsic Motivation

Extrinsic motivation has also been defined by Ryan and Deci (2000) as doing an activity “in order to attain some separable outcome” (p. 60). Motivation often comes from some external incentive, like the expectation to avoid a punishment or reap a reward. Some extrinsic motivations are also done for reinforcement. Examples include:

- Ironing your clothes to avoid the judgment of colleagues at work and to achieve their respect.
- Going to church to avoid the guilt of not going.
- Going to the gym to lose weight and impress potential romantic partners.

It is important to note that what makes an activity intrinsically or extrinsically motivated has nothing to do with the activity itself. In the three examples of ironing your clothes, going to church, and going to the gym, the actual activity remained the same. The reason for doing the activity determined the motivation for them.

Extrinsic motivation is not always bad

A lot of times, extrinsic motivation is given a bad reputation. However, sometimes being a responsible adult means forcing yourself to do something you do not enjoy doing. In those cases, extrinsic motivation is helpful. For example, filling out your tax forms or any type of paperwork may not be intrinsically motivating. Updating your passwords, checking the oil in your car, studying for an exam, and cleaning a cat’s litter box are all activities that many people do not intrinsically enjoy. However, they still need to be done. In these situations, we can use extrinsic motivation to accomplish these tasks. We can update our password to avoid dealing with identity theft. We can check the oil in our car to avoid getting stranded on the side of the road. We can study for an exam to pass a class. We can clean a litter box to have a healthy cat. When you consider your S.M.A.R.T. goals, the work required to accomplish those goals can often be extrinsically motivated. You may not enjoy the tasks intrinsically.

However, if all your activities are extrinsically motivated, you will not have enjoyment in your life. Although we all experience struggle and suffering, there is biblical precedent for embracing joyful activities. Nehemiah 8:10 (NIV) reminds us that “the joy of the Lord is your strength,” highlighting that joy is not only desirable but sustaining. Galatians 5:22 lists both joy and kindness as

fruit of the Spirit, emphasizing their interconnectedness in a life shaped by grace. One specific kind of joy arises in relationships marked by compassion and kindness, when we extend genuine care to others, we often experience deep, lasting fulfillment. Acts of kindness not only bless others but also nurture our own well-being, creating joy that is both intrinsically motivated and spiritually enriching. As you work toward your goals, make sure you are being available for intrinsically-motivated activities that allow space for joy, kindness, and authentic connection.

Performance vs. Mastery Goals

In the 1980s, Carol Dweck began researching the distinction between performance goals and mastery goals (originally known as learning goals). According to Dweck and her colleague, Elaine Elliott (1988), performance goals are present when “individuals seek to maintain positive judgments of their ability and avoid negative judgments by seeking to prove, validate, or document their ability and not discredit it” (p. 5). Mastery goals are present when “individuals seek to increase their ability or master new tasks” (p. 5).

Performance goals are about proving yourself. They can be further categorized into *approach-based* performance goals—trying to get an A to prove to yourself how smart you are—or *avoidance-based* performance goals—trying to avoid an F to prove to yourself you are not a failure (Elliot & Church, 1997). Mastery goals are about getting better at something. Either way, mastery goals are preferable to performance goals.

Elliott and Dweck’s (1988) research involved framing a task in such a way that it either encouraged mastery goals or performance goals. What they found was that when mastery goals were emphasized, students were more willing to take on more challenging tasks and were less likely to engage in negative self-talk.

Not only do mastery goals encourage you to challenge yourself, but they are also more aligned with a biblical worldview. In stewarding the life that God has given you, you are called to grow, develop, and faithfully use your gifts to bring glory to Him. As 1 Peter 4:10 (NIV) reminds us, “Each of you should use whatever gift you have received to serve others, as faithful stewards of God’s grace in its various forms.” You do not have to prove anything to God, nor do you need to prove anything to yourself—your worth is not based on performance. You are already completely loved; it is not earned but freely given through Christ (Romans 5:8). Rather than striving for approval, approaching your goals with a mastery mindset helps you grow in competence and character so that you can better fulfill the unique mission God has entrusted to you.

Mastery is not about perfection; it is about faithful progress.

This is especially important in an educational setting. If you are engaged in educational pursuits to prove something to yourself and others, then negative feedback on assignments and tests will be especially problematic. If the question that drives your education is: “Am I good enough?”, then negative feedback could give you the answer that you are not good enough, starting a downward spiral of dejection. On the other hand, if you have mastery goals and the question that drives your education is: “How can I increase my understanding and skills?”, then negative feedback will give you the answer on where you can work on increasing your skills, leading to an upward spiral of learning.

? Self-Assessment: Mastery or Performance Goal Motivation 3.1.1

Instructions

What is my motivation? Answer the following questions according to the following scale:

1: Never 2: Not often 3: Sometimes 4: Always

Mastery goal orientation:

1. I like to take on new challenges.
2. I like the feeling of competence when I have learned something new.
3. I feel a sense of satisfaction after I have gained a new skill.

Performance goal orientation:

4. It is very important to me that I get positive feedback when I am evaluated.
5. If I do poorly on a task it makes me want to quit.

6. I like to stick with what I know I am good at.

Scoring

Add up your scores for questions 1, 2, & 3. That is your **Mastery goal orientation score**.

Add up your scores for questions 4, 5, & 6. That is your **Performance goal orientation score**.

For which of the goal orientations did you have a higher score? Mastery or Performance?

Based on what you have learned about mastery and performance goals, do you think your scores are accurate? Why or why not?

Overall, how will you use the results of this assessment to guide your motivational approach in the future?

This assessment is also available as a PDF download: [3.1.1 - Self-Assessment Mastery or Performance Goal Motivation](#)

? Self-Reflection Prompts: Go Deeper! 3.1.2

This chapter focused on motivation. **Intrinsic motivation** is when you do a task because doing the task itself is rewarding. **Extrinsic motivation** is when you do a task because it will lead to an outside reward.

This chapter also presented the concept of performance goals and mastery (learning) goals. Performance goals are about evaluation of a product (i.e., your goal is to get an "A"). Mastery (learning) goals are about the learning (i.e., you want to be able to do a new skill).

Reflection Prompts

1. Consider a goal you are working toward right now. This might be one of the S.M.A.R.T. goals you created earlier, or it could be something broad like completing your undergraduate degree. Write a few sentences about WHY you are working toward that goal.
2. Read the sentences you wrote in response to question #1. Reflecting on what you wrote, is your motivation for your goal intrinsic or extrinsic? Is your goal a mastery goal or a performance goal? Explain your reasoning for your labels for your goal.
3. Looking back at your response to question #2, how do you feel about the labels you gave your goals? Do you approve of the types of goals and motivations that you have? If so, why? If not, why not? Do you think the types of goals and motivations you have will help you to succeed? Why or why not?

These questions are also available as a PDF download: [3.1.2 - Self-Reflection Prompts Go Deeper!](#)

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3.2: Kindness and Self-Motivation Devotional

Devotional for Kindness as a Catalyst for Self-Motivation

Scripture Readings

“Be kind and compassionate to one another, forgiving each other, just as in Christ God forgave you.” – Ephesians 4:32 (NIV)

“Those who are kind benefit themselves, but the cruel bring ruin on themselves.” – Proverbs 11:17 (NIV)

“Love is patient, love is kind. It does not envy, it does not boast, it is not proud.” – 1 Corinthians 13:4 (NIV)

Devotion

Kindness is often misunderstood as mere politeness or niceness. But from a biblical perspective, **kindness is strength wrapped in compassion**—a powerful fruit of the Spirit that reflects God’s mercy and grace through our everyday actions. As seen throughout Scripture, kindness is deeply rooted in love, humility, and a desire to serve others, even when it costs us something.

In the context of **self-motivation**, kindness plays a surprising, but vital, role. When we are driven by goals, deadlines, and personal achievement, it becomes easy to overlook the needs of others—or even the need to show grace to ourselves. But Spirit-led motivation is different. It is fueled not by pressure or pride, but by love and a desire to reflect Christ in all we do.

Kindness reminds us that our ambition should never come at the cost of compassion. True self-motivation, when led by the Spirit, includes time to pause, notice, and care for others and for our own souls. As Proverbs 11:17 points out, kindness is not just a blessing to others—it also brings life and well-being to ourselves.

Even small acts of kindness—offering a word of encouragement, being patient with someone’s mistakes, or simply listening—can become holy moments that shift the atmosphere. And just as important is the kindness we extend to ourselves: speaking with grace rather than criticism, allowing rest, and trusting that progress does not have to come through striving alone.

Ultimately, kindness fuels endurance. When our motivation is wrapped in mercy and grace, we are more likely to persevere with peace, treat others with love, and stay connected to the heart of God as we pursue our goals.

? Devotional Reflection Prompt: Food for Thought! 3.2.1

1. We tend to judge others in the same way we judge ourselves. When our goals are extrinsic and performative, we can easily slip into judging whether other people also measure up. If we are constantly looking for external verification of our worthiness, it is easy to unkindly hold others to those expectations as well. Have you ever noticed in yourself or in others a relationship between motivation and kindness? If so, what have you noticed? If not, what have you noticed is important for developing kindness?
2. Reflect on a time when someone showed you kindness in a stressful or challenging season. How did it impact your motivation or outlook?
3. In what ways can you build space into your daily routines or mindset that allows for kindness, even when you feel rushed or pressured?
4. Are there areas in your self-talk that lack grace? What would it look like to motivate yourself with kindness instead of criticism?
5. Re-read Ephesians 4:32. Who in your life right now could benefit from your kindness? How can you be intentional in responding to that need this week?

These questions are also available as a PDF download: [3.2.1 - Devotional Reflection Prompt Food for Thought!](#)

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3.3: Emotion Management

Emotion Management

Managing emotions is crucial for maintaining overall well-being. This section explores foundational theories from psychological literature regarding the nature of emotions, while also considering God's purposes for emotions and recognizing their functionality in our lives. By integrating psychological insights with a Christian perspective, we can develop effective strategies for emotional management that honor both our humanity and our faith.

Understanding Emotions: Theoretical Foundations

An emotion is a response to a situation that is relevant to a currently active goal. Your goals give meaning to a situation, and the meaning gives rise to the emotion. For example, if you are writing a paper and your goal is to finish a paper for a difficult class by midnight and your roommate interrupts you several times to engage in casual conversation, your emotion might be irritation. The meaning you give to her interruption is that he/she is inconsiderate or unaware. However, if you are on the computer to scroll through a social media feed to find ideas for what to wear to an outing and your roommate interrupts you, the meaning of his/her interruptions may be an attempt at developing a friendship and you may be less irritated.

The modal model of emotional generation (Gross, 2014) claims that we experience emotion through the following process:

- First, we find ourselves in a **situation**.
- Second, we give **attention** to a specific aspect of that situation.
- Third, we **appraise** the aspect that we have noticed which gives rise to an emotion.
- Finally, this emotion prompts a behavioral **response** that impacts the situation to influence or change it.

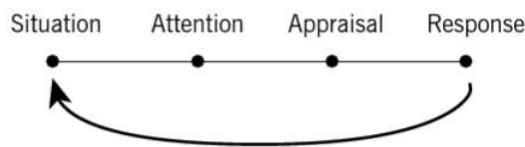


FIGURE 1.2. The modal model of emotion.

A key part of the sequence is the appraisal or meaning-making component. Another key part of the sequence is your behavioral response. Even if you feel an emotion, such as irritation toward your roommate, you are in control of your response to that emotion. You may say something bitingly sarcastic to your roommate, or you may kindly explain to her why you need to focus and why you need to put your headphones on to drown out distraction.

As you experience emotions it is important to assess **WHY** you feel the emotion, consider the meaning that you are assigning to a situation, and think before you engage in a response.

Emotional Regulation

In the chapter concerning self-awareness, you may have noticed habits or tendencies about yourself that you may consider unhealthy that you would like to change. For many of us, these concern emotions. Perhaps we are too often reluctant to engage with other people or try new things because of fear. Others of us hurt friends and family members because of anger. Some of us have a sense of shame that prevents us from confession and healing. For many of us, dealing with stress is a constant struggle. In these cases, you may want to use an emotional regulation strategy. Emotion-regulation strategies are ways to disrupt the modal model sequence of *situation-attention-appraisal-response*.

Here are some strategies to assist with emotional regulation:

Situation Selection. This addresses the very first step in the modal model sequence. With the emotional regulation strategy of situation selection, you avoid situations where you are most likely to experience an emotion. For example, if you are afraid of dogs, you avoid situations in which there are dogs to avoid the experience of fear. If a particular person makes you angry, you avoid situations where you will need to interact with that person to avoid the anger. This can be an acceptable strategy if you know the

strategy is time-bound. For example, if you had a bad experience with a professor and it is possible for you to not take a class with that professor again then you can use situation selection. However, it is not a good strategy overall. If you use avoidance as your primary regulation strategy, it can prevent you from enjoying the life God gave you. In fact, in some situations, people who engage in more avoidance strategies had increased depressive symptoms (Holahan et al., 2005).

Situation Modification. This strategy is also aimed at the situational aspect of the emotion sequence. In situation modification, you do not avoid a situation, but you prepare yourself for it and make small changes to change the emotion that comes from it. For example, if you are afraid of dogs, but your friend has a dog, you might ask her to keep it inside while you come over for a visit. Or perhaps you had a relationship that ended poorly and the memories are distressing. If you are invited to a social event that includes that person, you may ask to bring a friend or ask if you could come later to reduce the time spent with that person. Situation modification is generally more effective than situation selection. Controlling some parts of the situation is an active response which is associated with better health and well-being (Penley et al., 2002).

Attentional Deployment. Attentional deployment is a regulation strategy that works on the second step in the process of emotional experience: attention. Once you are in a situation, something about the situation draws your attention. Attentional deployment is a regulation strategy in which you remain in the situation but try to draw your attention away from things that might arouse emotion. For example, there may be something disgusting on the chair next to you during a meeting, so you try not to look at it or think about it. This is one of the least successful of all the emotional regulation strategies. Trying not to think about something almost always backfires. For example, try not to think about a giant magenta walrus. You are likely thinking about a giant magenta walrus right now, aren't you? Some research suggests that if you really want to work on the attention part of the emotion sequence, the best thing to do is to fill your attention with something else. For example, instead of thinking about a giant magenta walrus, think about Santa Claus dancing with a hula-hoop. The Bible speaks about how we are to think in Philippians 4:8 (NIV) where it states, "Finally, brothers and sisters, whatever is true, whatever is noble, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—think about such things."

Cognitive Change. Cognitive change works on the appraisal (third) step of the sequence of emotion. This strategy has to do with the meaning that is assigned to a situation. For example, if someone cuts you off in traffic, instead of assuming the worst about the person and getting angry, you consider the option that the person might need to get to a hospital due to a medical emergency. If you tend to respond to unexpected events or new challenges with stress, you could consider the challenges as opportunities for growth rather than threats. Cognitive reappraisal—that is, reinterpreting the meaning of the situation in benign or positive ways—is especially associated with positive physical and psychological outcomes (Maras & Leger, 2024). Cognitive reappraisal is one of the primary techniques used in cognitive behavioral therapy. For example, if you get a bad grade on an assignment, you could appraise the situation by believing that you are stupid or the professor does not like you. Instead, cognitive reappraisal reinterprets meaning to view the bad grade as a fluke since you usually do well in the class or that a different study strategy needs to be used for the next assignment.

Response Modulation. Response modulation does not affect the experience of an emotion, but is an intervention of the behavioral response to the felt emotion. For example, if you are frustrated by co-workers, you may choose to go for a long walk when you get home rather than snapping at them in the moment. Many of the coping mechanisms that are popular in contemporary wellbeing literature are about response modulation, including self-expression, exercise, relaxation techniques, positive self-talk, seeking social support, prayer, and meditation. Unfortunately, the use and abuse of drugs, alcohol, food, video games, and pornography are also response modulations. In many instances, experiencing an emotion is unavoidable and response modulation is an important strategy in experiencing emotions so that we do not engage in sinful behaviors. Emotions like anger, shame, guilt, fear, jealousy, anxiety, and loneliness can often lead us to sinful behaviors. Response modulation is about purposefully and mindfully acknowledging the emotion that we are experiencing and choosing an appropriate response.

? Self-Assessment: Emotion Management Test 3.3.1

Respond to Questions 1-6 below using the following options:

- 0 – completely disagree
- 1 – somewhat disagree
- 2 – neither disagree nor agree
- 3 – somewhat agree

- **4 – completely agree**

Questions:

1. Lately, I have been feeling completely overwhelmed.
2. Lately, I cannot seem to get in control of all the things going on in my life.
3. Lately, I have felt like I am drowning in things that demand my attention.
4. Lately, I have been feeling stressed almost all the time.
5. There have been times lately where I have just wanted to give up on everything.
6. I have noticed lately that I can feel the physical toll of stress on my body.

Calculate your total score by adding up all the points.

Score of 0–11: If your score was between 0 and 11, you appear to be managing your emotions effectively and maintaining a healthy emotional balance.

- Reflect on why you are not currently overwhelmed and how you will maintain a healthy level of stress. What strategies, habits, or support systems are helping you regulate your emotions well? Consider how you can continue reinforcing these practices to maintain emotional well-being during times of increased stress.

Score of 12–17: If your score was between 12 and 17, you may be experiencing occasional emotional strain.

- Reflect on strategies you will take to prevent becoming overwhelmed. Which specific emotions are harder for you to manage (e.g., anger, anxiety, sadness)? What strategies, habits, or support systems can help you prevent emotional overwhelm? Consider incorporating regular practices like journaling, deep breathing, talking with a trusted person, or setting emotional boundaries.

Score of 18–24: If your score was between 18 and 24, you may currently be struggling with managing your emotions effectively.

- Reflect on why you think you received this score and whether there are any responsibilities, goals, or commitments in your life that might be able to reduce stress.

Disclaimer: This scale is not diagnostic but is only intended for self-reflection. It has not undergone any rigorous scientific measures of validity or reliability.

This assessment is also available as a PDF download: [3.3.1 - Self-Assessment Emotion Management Test](#)

? Self-Assessment Reflection Questions for Emotion Management 3.3.2

1. Based on your total score, reflect on the possible sources of emotional overload, such as overwhelming responsibilities, unrealistic goals, or unresolved conflict. Consider what changes you might make to reduce emotional pressure. Are there commitments you can delegate or adjust? Would support from a counselor, mentor, or friend help you regain stability?
2. Write a short reflection (5 -7 sentences) summarizing what you have learned about your current emotional state and what practical next steps you can take to strengthen your emotional regulation.

These reflection questions are also available as a PDF download: [3.3.2 - Self-Assessment Reflection Questions for Emotion Management](#)

? Self-Reflection Prompts: Go Deeper! 3.3.3

For the following reflection, remember the five different emotional regulation strategies:

- Situation selection
- Situation modification
- Attentional deployment
- Cognitive change
- Response modulation

1. Think of a time when you used one of these emotional regulation strategies and it worked. What was the emotion you had that you wanted to regulate? What did you do to regulate it? Label the strategy from the list above and share why you think it was so successful.
 - Example: *A while back, I had a whole bunch of health scares all at once. I was completely stressed, so I used **attentional deployment** to focus on just one at a time. It worked because some were more urgent than others, and I really could prioritize my attention – I was not just ignoring the things I was stressed about.*
2. Think of a time when you used one of these emotional regulation strategies and it did NOT work for you. What was the emotion you had that you wanted to regulate? What did you do to try to regulate it? Label the strategy from the list above and share why you think it was NOT successful.
 - Example: *One semester, I thought I could handle eighteen credit hours plus softball. I was completely overwhelmed. I tried **situation modification** by creating a small desk space in my dorm room where I would do all my homework, and I put pictures of my family, and favorite Bible verses, and all the things that usually keep me calm. It was unsuccessful because I had to share my dorm room space with my roommate, who was a very loud and busy person. I did not have actual control of the situation I was trying to modify.*
3. Think of an emotion that you experience often that you would like to better regulate. Are there any emotional regulation strategies that you read about that you think you might be able to use? If so, which one and how would you use it?
 - Example: *I find myself getting jealous when I see other students doing well in classes that I think are much easier than the classes I am taking. I feel like it is not fair that they are going to get scholarships because of their high GPA from taking easy classes, while I must work twice as hard to get the same GPA because of the major I chose and the classes I take. I think I need to do some **cognitive change** with my performance goals and remind myself that I need to have mastery goals. In the end, it is not about the GPA; I must **master** this material if I want to go on to get my doctorate in medicine and save lives. I could also do **cognitive change** by reminding myself that God calls all of us to different careers and gives all of us different challenges.*

These questions are also available as a PDF download: [3.3.3 - Self-Reflection Prompts Go Deeper!](#)

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3.4: Faithfulness and Emotion Management

Devotional for Faithfulness and Managing Emotions in Times of Adversity

Scripture Readings

“The steadfast love of the Lord never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness.” – Lamentations 3:22–23 (ESV)

“Surely your goodness and love will follow me all the days of my life, and I will dwell in the house of the Lord forever.” – Psalm 23:6 (NIV)

“Who is wise and understanding among you? Let them show it by their good life, by deeds done in the humility that comes from wisdom.” – James 3:13 (NIV)

“Do not remember the sins of my youth and my rebellious ways; according to your love remember me, for you, Lord, are good.” – Psalm 25:7 (NIV)

“If we are faithless, he remains faithful, for he cannot disown himself.” – 2 Timothy 2:13 (NIV)

Devotion

Faithfulness is often seen as showing up, staying committed, and remaining consistent. While those things are true, biblical faithfulness is even deeper. It is about trusting in God's unchanging nature, especially when life feels unpredictable. In seasons of emotional overwhelm, when your heart is heavy and your mind is unsettled, faithfulness becomes a quiet act of strength, choosing to believe that God is near, even when you cannot feel Him.

Faithfulness is not about suppressing emotions or pretending everything is okay. Instead, it is about bringing your emotions—your fear, sadness, confusion, even anger—before God, trusting that He can hold it all. As the Psalms show us time and again, God welcomes emotional honesty. In fact, it is through this honest expression that we often rediscover His nearness and His unwavering love.

When we practice emotional management through the lens of faithfulness, we are not trying to “fix” our feelings. We are learning to be **anchored**, not in how we feel at any given moment, but in who God is: steady, good, merciful, and just. Our own ability to be faithful is rooted in His faithfulness to us.

Whether you are navigating disappointment, pressure, grief, or fear, let your faithfulness to God show in your endurance, your surrender, and your choice to continue seeking Him even when life feels like too much. That kind of faithfulness does not just change how you manage emotions—it transforms how you live.

? Devotional Reflection Prompts: Food for Thought! 3.4.1

Faithfulness plays a pivotal role in how we experience and respond to adversity. By anchoring our hope, fostering community support, and promoting spiritual maturity, faithfulness enables us to navigate life's challenges with resilience and grace. How do we stay faithful and stay the course, especially when we get overwhelmed or are completely stressed out? Thanks be to God; He will provide a way. Let us seek wisdom to live faithfully.

1. Think of times in your life when you have seen faithfulness in other people. What are some characteristics of those people that stand out to you as faithful? How do you think those people developed those characteristics?
2. What stories from the Bible or from people in your life can you remind yourself of the next time you are tempted to doubt God's faithfulness?

These questions are also available as a PDF download: [3.4.1 - Devotional Reflection Prompt Food for Thought!](#)

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

4: Control - Mastering Personal Responsibility and Flourishing for Life

[4.1: Self-Discipline](#)

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[4.3: Self-Management and Flourishing](#)

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*"True power lies not in controlling the world around you, but in mastering the decisions
you make
and taking full responsibility for your journey." - Author Unknown*

The final stage of stewarding your life centers on embracing personal responsibility, not as a burden, but as a sacred opportunity to live intentionally and bear lasting fruit. Taking control in a Christian sense means aligning your actions, habits, and choices with the guidance of the Holy Spirit. It is about mastering the everyday decisions that shape your character and direction. Through self-discipline and self-control, you develop healthy patterns that reflect God's wisdom and love—habits that build consistency, strength, and integrity over time. This is not about rigid perfection, but about faithful stewardship—responding to God's call with practical obedience in the details of daily life.

Staying the course on this journey of self-management requires endurance, vision, and grace. There will be days of momentum and days of resistance, but a heart rooted in Christ can persevere with confidence, commitment, challenge, and control. Flourishing is not merely reaching your goals, it is becoming who God created you to be, living with purpose, peace, and joy. As you take ownership of your habits and responsibilities, empowered by God's Spirit, you begin to experience a life of abundance—not just for yourself, but for those you influence. This final part is an invitation to walk forward in maturity and faith, cultivating a life that honors God and thrives in every season.

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4.1: Self-Discipline

Self-Discipline - The Science of Habit Formation

Self-discipline is a vital aspect of personal growth and spiritual development. It empowers individuals to make intentional choices that align with their values and goals. From a psychological perspective, understanding the science of habit formation can provide valuable insights into cultivating self-discipline. This chapter explores the psychology behind self-discipline, the mechanisms of habit formation, and practical strategies to develop lasting healthy habits from a Christian perspective.

Understanding Self-Discipline

Self-discipline refers to the ability to control one's impulses, emotions, and behaviors to achieve long-term goals. It involves making decisions that may be difficult in the moment but lead to greater rewards in the future. This aligns with Proverbs 25:28 (NIV), which states, "Like a city whose walls are broken through is a person who lacks self-control." Here, the metaphor of a city without walls illustrates the vulnerability that comes with a lack of discipline.

Types of Self-Discipline

- *Active Discipline*
 - Self-control or willpower
 - The ability to manage your thoughts, emotions, and actions in the moment
 - Making conscious choices that align with your long-term aspirations
- *Reactive Discipline*
 - Ability to manage your emotions
 - Controlling your thoughts and behaviors in response to unexpected or challenging situations
 - Learning from adversity
- *Proactive Discipline*
 - Preventative
 - Planning and preparation in advance to maintain control over a situation

Strategies to Cultivate Self-Discipline

- **Create a Routine** - Establishing a daily routine can significantly enhance self-discipline. Incorporate habits into a structured schedule, making them a non-negotiable part of your day. For example, if prayer is a goal, designate a specific time and place each day for prayer and reflection. Consistency in routine reinforces habit formation and helps make behaviors automatic.
- **Use Accountability** - Accountability can bolster self-discipline. Sharing goals with a trusted friend or mentor can provide external motivation and support. Consider forming a small group with like-minded people to encourage one another in spiritual disciplines, such as studying Scripture or engaging in acts of service. This communal approach fosters a sense of responsibility and strengthens commitment.
- **Practice Mindfulness** - Mindfulness practices, such as meditation or reflective prayer, can enhance self-awareness and self-discipline. By being present and aware of our thoughts and feelings, we can better recognize temptations and triggers that may lead us away from our goals. Mindfulness allows us to pause and choose our responses intentionally, rather than reacting impulsively.
- **Embrace Grace and Forgiveness** - In the pursuit of self-discipline, it is crucial to acknowledge that setbacks are a natural part of the process. In the Christian faith, we are reminded of God's grace and forgiveness. When we falter, we should not dwell in guilt but rather learn from our experiences and continue to strive for growth. This perspective fosters resilience, allowing us to commit ourselves to our goals with renewed determination.

The Role of Willpower

Willpower is often seen as the cornerstone of self-discipline. It is the mental capacity to resist short-term temptations in favor of long-term goals (American Psychological Association, 2012). However, research suggests that willpower is a **finite** resource, subject to depletion. Baumeister and Tierney's (2011) research indicates that engaging in tasks requiring self-control can reduce

willpower, leading to a phenomenon known as ego depletion. While willpower can be helpful in short bursts, it is far better to build sustainable habits rather than relying solely on willpower.

The Science of Habit Formation

Habits are automatic behaviors that emerge from repeated actions. Understanding the psychology of habit formation can enhance our ability to cultivate self-discipline. According to Charles Duhigg's (2014) "habit loop" model, habits consist of three components: cue (or trigger), routine, and reward.

- **Cue** - A cue is a trigger that initiates a habitual behavior. It can be an external stimulus (like a time of day or a location) or an internal state (like feeling stressed or bored). Recognizing and acknowledging cues in our daily lives is crucial for habit formation. For instance, if you want to start exercising every morning, you can put your shoes and clothes next to your bed the night before and put them on right when you wake up. Or, if you want to establish a habit of reading the Bible daily, you might choose to do so first thing in the morning, using the morning light as the cue or trigger.
- **Routine** - The routine is the behavior itself, the action taken in response to the cue. This could be anything from exercising, praying, or studying Scripture. Establishing a routine that aligns with personal values and goals makes it easier to integrate new habits into daily life.
- **Reward** - The reward is the positive reinforcement that follows the routine. It can be a feeling of satisfaction, a sense of achievement, or even physical rewards like treating oneself after completing a task. Positive reinforcement encourages repetition of behavior, solidifying the habit over time. Utilizing the morning exercise example, the reward could be a better feeling of self or healthy smoothie that you like.

Establishing Lasting Healthy Habits

1. Start Small

- To establish lasting habits, begin with small, manageable changes. For example, if your goal is to exercise regularly, start with just ten minutes a day. Gradually, increase the duration as the habit becomes more ingrained. Small successes build confidence and momentum, making it easier to tackle larger goals.

2. Celebrate Progress

- Recognizing and celebrating progress is essential for maintaining motivation. Acknowledge small victories along the way, whether it is completing a week of daily prayer or reaching a fitness milestone. Celebrations can range from personal reflections to sharing successes with others, reinforcing the positive feelings associated with habit formation.

3. Revisit and Adjust

- Regularly revisiting goals and strategies allows for reflection and adjustment. Life circumstances may change, requiring modifications to our routines or objectives. Being flexible and willing to adapt ensures that our habits remain relevant and attainable, fostering a sense of purpose in our self-discipline journey.

Self-discipline is a vital component of personal growth and spiritual development, rooted in the understanding of habit formation and the psychology behind behavior change. By integrating psychological principles with a Christian perspective, we can cultivate self-discipline in ways that honor God and align with our values.

As we set clear goals, establish routines, practice mindfulness, and embrace grace, we empower ourselves to form lasting, healthy habits. These habits not only enhance our daily lives but also deepen our relationship with God, enabling us to live out our faith more fully. In the pursuit of self-discipline, we find that the journey is as important as the destination, allowing us to grow and mature in our walk with Christ. Through God's guidance and our commitment to self-discipline, we can navigate the complexities of life with grace and purpose, reflecting His light in all we do.

? Self-Assessment: Health Habits 4.1.1

Developing and maintaining healthy habits takes time and consistency. As you commit to change, you will find that you must trust the process. Ask yourself, "How ready am I to make healthy habit changes?"

Answer Yes or No in response to each question below. Do not overthink it. Go with your gut.

1. I have a routine that allows me to get about seven hours of sleep each night.

2. I have moderated my sleep environment to make sure I get good quality sleep.
3. I have a routine that allows me to get about 150 minutes of physical activity a week.
4. I eat a variety of foods that include fruits, vegetables, and whole grains.
5. I do not smoke.
6. I only use drugs that are prescribed for me and for their prescribed purpose.
7. I have a routine for my hygiene habits (showering, brushing my teeth, etc.).
8. I know my triggers for unhealthy habits like alcohol misuse, drugs, unhealthy media viewing, unhealthy eating, or unhealthy conversations.
9. I spend some time outdoors each week.
10. I spend quality time each week with people who love me.
11. I have developed a habit of prayer, worship, devotion, or meditation.
12. I organize my time so that my most important tasks are accomplished when I am the most energized.
13. I have an organizational system that prevents me from forgetting deadlines and appointments.
14. I have found a physical space that I can use when I need to work without interruption.

SCORING

Add the number of *Yes* responses to the statements: The maximum score is fourteen.

Scores between 10-14: Healthy habit superstar!

Scores between 7-9: You are on the way to healthy habits.

Scores below 6: Time to implement new habit loops!

Disclaimer: This scale is not diagnostic but is only intended for self-reflection. It has not undergone any rigorous scientific measures of validity or reliability.

This assessment is also available as a PDF download: [4.1.1 - Self-Assessment Health Habits](#)

? Self-Assessment Reflection Questions for Health Habits 4.1.2

1. How did you feel about your score on your healthy habits assessment?
2. Are you proud of how well you did?
3. Did you notice a specific question that might motivate you to start a new healthy habit?
4. Choose one of the questions you answered *No* to and write about how you might address that question.
5. If you did not answer *No* to any of the questions, write about how you will continue to maintain your healthy habits.

These reflection questions are also available as a PDF download: [4.1.2 - Self-Assessment Reflection Questions for Health Habits](#)

? Self-Reflection Prompts: Go Deeper! 4.1.3

Oftentimes, when we think about self-discipline, we think about willpower and self-control. The following questions are meant to get you thinking about how you govern yourself and your time.

1. What does self-discipline mean to you? Do you consider yourself to be self-disciplined?
2. Who is really in control of you and your time? Are you pulled in different directions by the demands of others?
3. Are there things that you would like to do that never get close to getting done?
4. In what areas are you most self-disciplined?
5. What is the difference between self-discipline and habit?

These questions are also available as a PDF download: [4.1.3 - Self-Reflection Prompts Go Deeper!](#)

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4.2: Self-Control and Self-Discipline Devotional

Devotional for Gentleness, Self-Control, and Self-Discipline

Scripture Readings

“God’s Spirit makes us loving, happy, peaceful, patient, kind, good, faithful, gentle, and self-controlled. There is no law against behaving in any of these ways.” – Galatians 5:22–23 (CEV)

“You see, God did not give us a cowardly spirit but a powerful, loving, and disciplined spirit.” – 2 Timothy 1:7 (The Voice)

“A man [person] without self-control is like a city broken into and left without walls.” – Proverbs 25:28 (ESV)

Devotion

In our spiritual growth journey, few things are more foundational than **self-discipline**, but it is how we approach it that makes all the difference. As Christians, we are not called to strive endlessly through self-condemnation or harshness. Instead, Scripture teaches that **gentleness and self-control** are not only spiritual fruits but essential tools in practicing healthy, grace-filled discipline.

Gentleness is often mistaken for weakness, but biblically, it is *strength wrapped in humility*. When Paul calls believers to restore others “in a spirit of gentleness” (Galatians 6:1, ESV), he is encouraging a powerful, healing posture—one that corrects without crushing. And this applies not only to our relationships with others but also to ourselves.

Many of us are our own harshest critics. When we fail to meet goals or struggle with discipline, we often respond with shame. But Jesus models something different. In Matthew 11:28-30, He invites the weary and burdened to come to Him—not with performance, but with surrender and a promise of rest. His yoke is **gentle**, and in Him, we learn to walk in grace.

Self-control, on the other hand, gives structure and strength to that gentleness. It empowers us to live with **intentionality** and **boundaries**, guarding our hearts and actions from things that distract or destroy. Proverbs 25:28 paints a vivid picture of a life without self-control: like a city with broken walls, vulnerable to anything that comes its way.

Self-control does not mean perfection, nor does it mean we never struggle. Instead, it means we rely on the Spirit to guide our choices, knowing we have been given the power to live disciplined, focused lives rooted in love and wisdom (2 Timothy 1:7).

Together, gentleness and self-control provide a balanced path toward self-discipline. They keep us humble, patient, and persistent—able to grow, correct, and continue in grace.

? Devotional Reflection Prompts: Food for Thought! 4.2.1

Why would gentleness and self-control/self-discipline be paired together? The two are closely related. To have self-control, you must have gentleness. It is how we equip ourselves to serve well. It helps us practice restraint, especially in difficult situations. Think about how gentleness and self-control may impact how you interact with people. Take time to reflect on this devotional and its interconnectedness with self-discipline.

This question is also available as a PDF download: [4.2.1 - Devotional Reflection Prompts Food for Thought!](#)

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4.3: Self-Management and Flourishing

Self-Management and Flourishing

As we reflect on the journey of Christian self-management, it is crucial to recognize how the principles discussed throughout this text interconnect to create an integrated approach to flourishing. This chapter synthesizes the fruit of the Spirit devotional themes, illustrating how these attributes empower us to manage ourselves effectively and lead lives that reflect Christ's character. Flourishing, in this context, means experiencing life in its fullness, embracing our identities in Christ, and manifesting the transformative power of the Holy Spirit.

The Essence of Flourishing

Flourishing is not merely about achieving personal goals or accumulating successes; it represents a deep and abiding sense of well-being rooted in our relationship with God and others. A biblical understanding of flourishing encompasses spiritual, emotional, and relational dimensions. It is a state of being where we experience joy, purpose, and connection, allowing us to reflect God's love and grace in all we do.

This flourishing is deeply connected to the fruit of the Spirit, which serves as a framework for our growth as individuals and as members of the Christian community. Each fruit provides a unique aspect of character that not only shapes our personal lives but also influences how we engage with the world around us.

Integrating Fruit into a Flourishing Life

The integration of the fruit of the Spirit into our daily lives creates a framework for effective self-management and flourishing. Each fruit contributes to a well-rounded character, enriching our experiences and relationships. Here are some key strategies for integrating these fruits into our lives:

1. Daily Reflection and Surrender

- Incorporating daily reflection and surrender to the Holy Spirit is essential for allowing these fruits to flourish. This practice invites God's guidance and power into our decision-making processes. By seeking the Spirit's leading, we open ourselves to transformative growth and align our actions with His will.

2. Goal Setting Aligned with Spiritual Values

- Setting goals that reflect the fruit of the Spirit enables us to live intentionally. For instance, we might aim to practice kindness by volunteering regularly or to cultivate self-control by committing ourselves to a healthier lifestyle. These intentional goals keep us focused on our spiritual growth and help us navigate life's challenges with purpose.

3. Building Supportive Relationships

- Engaging with a community of fellow believers fosters accountability and encouragement. Sharing our journeys, celebrating progress, and supporting one another in times of difficulty enrich our experiences and promote flourishing. Participating in small groups or church activities provides opportunities to practice the fruit of the Spirit collectively.

4. Embracing Spiritual Disciplines

- Engaging in spiritual disciplines—such as prayer, worship, and Bible study—nurtures our relationship with God and empowers us to embody the fruit of the Spirit. These practices provide strength and guidance, helping us remain grounded in our faith as we navigate life's complexities.

5. Fostering a Growth Mindset

- Embracing a growth mindset allows us to view challenges as opportunities for development rather than obstacles. This perspective encourages resilience and persistence, reinforcing our commitment to cultivating the fruits of the Spirit in all areas of life.

Flourishing as Christians is a dynamic process that involves continual growth and transformation. As we allow the Holy Spirit to work within us, we become more attuned to the character of Christ, reflecting His love and grace in our interactions. This journey is not merely about personal achievement but about becoming conduits of God's transformative power in the world.

Living out the fruit of the Spirit positions us to impact our communities positively. When we embody love, joy, peace, and other fruits, we create environments where others can also flourish. Our lives become testimonies of God's goodness, inviting others to experience the abundant life He offers.

? Self-Assessment: Where are you now? 4.3.1

Instructions

Using this assessment tool, you will evaluate patterns in your thinking, behavior, and emotional regulation. Each section encourages honest reflection on how you respond to life's demands and opportunities, not just for personal development, but as a form of faithful stewardship of your time, energy, and calling.

Rate how true each statement is for you over the past month using this scale:

- 1 = Not at all true
- 2 = Slightly true
- 3 = Somewhat true
- 4 = Mostly true
- 5 = Completely true

Section 1: Confidence (10 questions)

Assesses belief in self, resilience, and optimism. This section evaluates your ability to navigate life with God-given assurance. Are you grounded in your identity in Christ?

1. I believe I can overcome personal setbacks.
2. I regularly acknowledge my strengths and skills.
3. I feel equipped to make important decisions.
4. I bounce back quickly after disappointment or failure.
5. I can identify what makes me unique and valuable.
6. I trust my judgment, even when others doubt me.
7. I view challenges as opportunities to gain experience.
8. I maintain a positive outlook even in tough times.
9. I am comfortable asserting my opinions respectfully.
10. I feel capable of reaching my long-term goals.

Section 2: Commitment (10 questions)

Assesses persistence, purpose alignment, and daily intentionality. This section explores whether your goals reflect what matters most to you and to God. Do your actions show faithfulness and commitment to your purpose and to the people you have been called to serve?

11. I set meaningful personal and professional goals.
12. I follow through on what I say I will do.
13. I can stay focused even when I lose motivation.
14. I make decisions based on my values and priorities.
15. I reflect regularly on whether my actions align with my purpose.
16. I track progress on important goals or habits.
17. I keep commitments even when they are inconvenient.
18. I adjust my course when needed without giving up.
19. I stay loyal to the people and causes that matter to me.
20. I live each day with a sense of intention.

Section 3: Challenge (10 questions)

Assesses adaptability, stress management, and willingness to stretch limits. Transformation often requires moving through discomfort. This section explores how you handle uncertainty and whether you see trials as opportunities for growth.

21. I regularly stretch outside my comfort zone.
22. I seek growth opportunities, even when they are difficult.
23. I can manage uncertainty without becoming overwhelmed.
24. I embrace constructive feedback and use it to grow.
25. I respond to pressure with focus rather than panic.
26. I welcome complex problems as opportunities to gain experience.
27. I am willing to try again after setbacks.
28. I accept that discomfort is part of progress.
29. I ask for help when challenges exceed my current ability.
30. I find energy in working toward difficult goals.

Section 4: Control (10 questions)

Assesses self-regulation, boundaries, and effective time and energy use. Stewardship involves wise and disciplined self-management. This section evaluates how well you manage your habits, focus, and emotional responses.

31. I set healthy boundaries with my time and attention.
32. I manage my time in a way that reflects my priorities.
33. I keep emotions in check when making decisions.
34. I do not let distractions derail my focus for long.
35. I build habits that support my mental and physical well-being.
36. I regularly review and adjust my routines.
37. I take ownership of my choices and their outcomes.
38. I can say “no” when something does not align with my goals.
39. I plan proactively instead of always reacting.
40. I end my day feeling I have used my time wisely.

Scoring & Interpretation - Total Score Range: 40 (lowest) – 200 (highest)

Section Scores - Add up the scores from each of the four sections.

1.
 - Confidence: Q1–Q10 - Total:
 - Commitment: Q11–Q20 - Total:
 - Challenge: Q21–Q30 - Total:
 - Control: Q31–Q40 - Total:
2. Scoring Key (Per Section and Total):
 - **40–50: Flourishing** – Strong and sustainable self-management: You are stewarding your life well. Practices are strong, sustainable, and rooted in a clear sense of calling. Continue deepening your growth through spiritual disciplines and reflection.
 - **30–39: Developing** – Some strong practices, but there is room for growth: You are on the right track. Some healthy patterns are present, but there is space for refinement. Identify small adjustments to better align your daily practices with your purpose.
 - **20–29: Struggling** – Inconsistent habits or awareness: This area may be inconsistent or reactive. Take time to examine where discouragement, distraction, or disconnection is showing up and seek guidance to build new rhythms.
 - **10–19: Stalled** – Needs support and intentional focus: You may feel stuck, overwhelmed, or disconnected from your goals and values. Consider inviting support through prayer, community, counseling, or coaching to rebuild from a place of grace.

This assessment is also available as a PDF download: [4.3.1 - Self-Assessment Where are you now](#)

? Self-Assessment Reflection Questions for "Where are you now?" 4.3.2

1. After completing the assessment, how do you feel based on where you were when you started this journey to where you are presently?

2. Which section(s) did you score highest and lowest in?
3. To what do you need to pay more attention?
4. What is one habit or mindset shift you will begin to practice in the next week?

These reflection questions are also available as a PDF download: [4.3.2 - Self-Assessment Reflection Questions for Where are you now](#)

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4.4: From This Day Forward - Staying the Course Devotional

Devotional for Staying the Course – A Flourishing Life of Intentional Self-Management

Scripture Readings

“But the Holy Spirit produces this kind of fruit in our lives: love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, ²³ gentleness, and self-control. There is no law against these things!” – Galatians 5:22-23 (NLT)

“I have not stopped thanking God for you. I pray for you constantly, asking God, the glorious Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, to give you spiritual wisdom and insight so that you might grow in your knowledge of God. I pray that your hearts will be flooded with light so that you can understand the confident hope he has given to those he called—his holy people who are his rich and glorious inheritance.” – Ephesians 1:16-18 (NLT)

“Let us not become weary in doing good, for at the proper time we will reap a harvest if we do not give up.” – Galatians 6:9 (NIV)

“Remain in me, as I also remain in you. No branch can bear fruit by itself; it must remain in the vine.” – John 15:4 (NIV)

“His divine power has given us everything we need for a godly life through our knowledge of him who called us by his own glory and goodness.” – 2 Peter 1:3 (NIV)

Devotion

In our journey toward spiritual maturity and personal growth, staying the course can often feel like the hardest part. It is not starting well or setting good intentions that challenge us most—it is remaining consistent when we are tired, discouraged, or distracted. Yet God has given us everything we need to not only run the race but to finish it with fruitfulness and grace.

The fruit of the Spirit, as outlined in Galatians 5:22–23, offers us a holistic framework for Christian self-management—a life lived in step with the Spirit and grounded in God’s love. Each virtue not only reflects Christ’s character but also serves as a tool for perseverance and faithful living.

Love and Self-Management

The foundation of flourishing is love, which encompasses our relationship with God and our interactions with others. Love is selfless and unconditional, urging us to prioritize the needs of others and foster genuine connections. In self-management, practicing love translates into making choices that reflect compassion, empathy, and service.

Joy and Self-Perspective

Joy is a profound sense of well-being that transcends our circumstances. Unlike fleeting happiness, joy is anchored in our relationship with Christ and is cultivated through gratitude and worship. In the context of self-management, joy encourages us to maintain a positive outlook, focus on the blessings in our lives, and nurture relationships that bring us closer to God.

Peace and Goal Setting

Peace is the inner tranquility that comes from trusting God amidst life’s challenges. It allows us to navigate stress and conflict with grace, embodying the assurance that God is in control. Self-management practices that promote peace include prayer, meditation, and engaging in calming activities that center our hearts and minds on God’s presence.

Patience and Time Management

Patience is the ability to endure trials and delays without frustration. It fosters resilience and character, allowing us to trust in God's timing. In self-management, cultivating patience helps us approach challenges with a calm spirit, fostering perseverance and a deeper relationship with God as we learn to wait on Him.

Kindness and Self-Motivation

Kindness and goodness are expressions of love that enhance our relationships and foster community. They compel us to act with integrity and compassion in our daily lives. Self-management in this realm means actively seeking opportunities to serve others, engage in acts of kindness, and make choices that reflect our commitment to goodness.

Faithfulness and Emotion Management

Faithfulness signifies reliability and commitment, both to us and to our responsibilities. It is about being trustworthy in our relationships and steadfast in our faith. In self-management, faithfulness involves setting and adhering to personal goals that align with our values, building a solid foundation for a flourishing life.

Gentleness, Self-Control, and Self-Discipline

Gentleness is strength under control. It allows us to approach others with humility and care, fostering healthy and constructive interactions. Practicing gentleness in self-management encourages us to respond thoughtfully rather than react impulsively, creating a supportive environment for personal and communal growth.

Self-control is crucial for managing our impulses and making intentional choices. It empowers us to pursue long-term goals rather than succumbing to immediate gratification. In the context of self-management, developing self-control involves establishing healthy habits, setting boundaries, and remaining focused on our commitments.

? Devotional Reflection Prompts: Food for Thought! 4.4.1

The pairings of the fruit of the spirit and self-management themes are joy and self-perspective; peace and goal setting; patience and time-management; kindness and self-motivation; faithfulness and stress-management. gentleness, self-control, and self-discipline.

As we conclude, consider the pairings of the fruit of the Spirit and self-management theme. Choose one and reflect on how the two are related in your life.

These questions are also available as a PDF download: [4.4.1 - Devotional Reflection Prompts Food for thought](#)

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Glossary

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About the Authors

Dr. Rakisha Vinegar is an accomplished higher education administrator and dedicated advocate for student success and development. With a strong academic foundation and a passion for empowering individuals, Dr. Vinegar has spent over twenty-five years working in various administrative roles within healthcare and higher education institutions. She holds a Master of Business Administration and a Doctorate in Education with a concentration in Ethical Leadership and has a particular focus on student experience, retention, and creating inclusive academic environments.

In addition to her administrative work, Dr. Vinegar is an author whose writings reflect her deep commitment to personal growth, leadership development, and faith-based principles. Her work seeks to inspire and equip both students and professionals to embrace their potential, fostering a deeper understanding of self-management and holistic success.

Dr. Vinegar's leadership style is rooted in her belief that education is not only about academic achievement but also about nurturing the whole person—intellectually, emotionally, and spiritually. Her leadership initiatives have been instrumental in promoting diversity, community-building, and innovative educational practices. She continues to serve as a mentor and advocate, striving to make a lasting impact on the higher education landscape and the lives of students and faculty alike. She is dedicated to supporting individuals from all walks of life in realizing their full potential, both in their academic endeavors and personal lives.

When she is not working on her next research project or consulting organizations, Dr. Vinegar enjoys kayaking and any outdoor activity. She enjoys engaging in community outreach, public speaking, and personal reflection through writing and journaling.

Dr. Jessica Clevering is a distinguished social psychologist. In a career spanning over 15 years, she has helped students develop a Christian understanding of the self. Dr. Clevering holds a Ph.D. and M.A. in Psychology. As a Professor of Psychology at Trinity Christian College, where she specializes in the intersection of psychology, student development, and academic success, she has mentored over thirty students in their professional presentations. Dr. Clevering has a deep passion for understanding the social dynamics that influence learning, motivation, and the overall student experience. Her publications include “System Justification Theory and Multicultural Training in Counselor Education” and “Help Seeking Attitudes – Not Behaviors – Predict Academic Performance in College.”

Throughout her career, Dr. Clevering has been dedicated to fostering inclusive and supportive environments that promote student well-being and achievement. She incorporates both evidence-based psychological theories and practical strategies in her teaching to help students develop not only academically but also socially and emotionally. Dr. Clevering is known for her ability to bridge the gap between psychological theory and practical application in educational contexts, ensuring that students leave her classes equipped with valuable insights into their own learning processes and interpersonal relationships.

Dr. Clevering is dedicated to advancing higher education through innovative teaching practices and impactful research. Her work continues to shape how institutions understand and respond to the social and psychological needs of students, ensuring that education is not only an academic pursuit but a holistic developmental experience.

In addition to her professional pursuits, Dr. Clevering enjoys exploring new cultures through travel and spending quality time with her family. She lives in the suburbs of Chicago with her husband, daughter, and native plant garden.

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